

Singh Kushwaha (25), a UPSC aspirant, was returning home after studying at a library. “Two men intercepted him, choked him, assaulted him with fists and robbed him of his mobile phone before fleeing on foot,” an officer said. An FIR was registered at Timarpur police station, following which a special team launched an investigation.

The team examined footage from around 110 CCTV cameras and traced the movement of the suspects.

CM Rekha seeks ₹100 crore from Centre for PM-UDAY scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has written to Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal requesting ₹100 crore in first-phase funding under the Urban Development Fund for the effective implementation of the revised PM-UDAY scheme.

The funds will be used for setting up PM-UDAY cells in all 13 districts, developing a DRISHTI-based modern land survey and mapping system, and conducting a large-scale public awareness campaign across Delhi's 1,511 unauthorised colonies.

The revised PM-UDAY regulations were notified on April 6, 2026, providing a new legal framework for granting property rights to residents of unauthorised colonies. The provision to regularise these colonies on an as-is-where-is basis is intended to make the process of securing property rights simpler for a large number of residents.

The Delhi Government's Revenue Department has been designated as the nodal agency for the scheme's implementation. Under its expanded responsibilities, the department will establish PM-UDAY cells in all 13 districts, each

headed by an additional district magistrate. A comprehensive exercise covering physical verification of properties, digital mapping using modern technology, and updating of land records across all 1,511 unauthorised colonies will be undertaken.

The entire scheme is designed to issue property-related documents and authorisation letters within a 45-day timeline.

Of the ₹100 crore sought for 2026-27, the largest component is ₹65 crore earmarked for developing the modern land survey and mapping system under the DRISHTI initiative. This system will make the property verifica-



tion and land records modernisation process more transparent, accurate, and technology-driven.

The second component of ₹25 crore is proposed for

setting up the PM-UDAY cells across all 13 districts and at headquarters. The Chief Minister said in her letter that without these cells, it would not be possible to

issue the required documents within the stipulated 45-day timeline.

The third component of Rs 10 crore is proposed for public awareness and outreach activities.

These funds would be used to organise workshops with Resident Welfare Associations, establish help desks, disseminate information on Standard Operating Procedures, explain the role of ADMs in the process, inform residents about important eligibility-related dates, and spread awareness through single-window camps across the city.

The Chief Minister noted that the institutional frame-

work required for implementing the scheme has already been notified and work has commenced. She said timely Central government financial support will help ensure that lakhs of Delhi residents receive property rights at the earliest.

Delhi's unauthorised colonies have been a long-standing governance challenge. The city has 1,511 colonies that have been identified for regularisation, housing millions of residents who have lived there for decades without formal property titles. The PM-UDAY scheme, originally launched in 2019, aims to give these residents ownership rights

so they can use their properties as legal assets, access formal credit, and gain security of tenure.

However, implementation has been slow, with land surveys, mapping, and the processing of individual applications posing significant logistical challenges.

The revised regulations notified in April 2026 and the as-is-where-is regularisation provision are intended to simplify the process.

The ₹100 crore request is aimed at building the infrastructure and institutional capacity needed to actually deliver on those simplified rules at scale within a defined timeframe.

Man killed after speeding SUV hits him in Rajouri Garden, driver held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A speeding SUV fatally struck a 45-year-old man as he walked home with a friend on the roadside after finishing work in Rajouri Garden, and police arrested the driver and seized the vehicle, officials said on Sunday.

Police said the accident occurred on Saturday in West Delhi, and they arrested the absconding driver on Sunday. The deceased was identified as Uday Kumar, also known as Uday Mahato, a resident of Khyala, who worked at a private shop in Rajouri Garden.

According to police, Uday was walking home with his friend, Subhash Kumar, a resident of Raghunagar, after finishing work, when a speeding Scorpio hit him and fled the scene. "The speeding SUV struck Uday, while his friend narrowly escaped," an eyewitness told police during the investigation.

Subhash rushed the injured man to Guru Gobind



A speeding SUV seized after the driver fatally struck a 45-year-old man as he walked home with a friend on the roadside after finishing work in Rajouri Garden in New Delhi

PTI

Singh Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead.

Police said after they received information about the accident through a hospital notification, a team reached the hospital and started an enquiry.

The eyewitness shared the offending vehicle's registration number with police, which helped investigators identify the suspect.

Police said the crime team inspected the accident spot, although the SUV had already fled.

Police registered an FIR and arrested the accused driver, identified as 25-year-old Devansh Kumar, a resident of Naraina Vihar, and seized the vehicle involved in the accident.

Police said the post-mortem was conducted and the body was handed over to the victim's family.

On Saturday, family members, including the deceased's wife and two children, demanded immediate action against the driver. Police said further investigation is underway.

Over 2.73 lakh candidates register for DU UG admissions 2026-27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Over 2.73 lakh aspirants have registered for undergraduate admissions at the University of Delhi for the 2026-27 academic session, officials said on Sunday.

According to university officials, 2,73,751 candidates signed up on the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal, of whom 2,18,284 completed their registrations. Of those who completed registration, 97,775 are male candidates and 1,20,509 are female candidates, according to university data.

As many as 2,06,835 aspirants have also submitted their programme and college preferences under the second phase of the admission process, they said.

The top 10 preferred programmes included BCom (Hons), BCom, BA (Hons) English, BA (Hons) Political Science, BA Programme (History and Political



Science), BA (Hons) History, BSc (Hons) in Zoology, Mathematics, BSc programme Life Science and BA (Hons) Economics, they said.

The second phase of the undergraduate admission process, which began on July 3, concluded on July 11, during which the candidates were required to map their CUET-UG 2026 subjects with those studied in Class 12 and submit their preferred programme and college combinations.

Officials said the university will declare simulated ranks on the CSAS portal at 5 pm on Sunday. Candidates

DDA issues SOP for anti-encroachment drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has issued a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for Flying Squad Teams and Quick Response Teams to enforce zero-tolerance against encroachments on DDA and government land, with 14 Flying Squad Teams constituted across DDA zones for systematic field inspections with geo-tagged documentation and four dedicated Quick Response Teams tasked with completing demolition of detected unauthorised constructions within 72 hours of detection.

ised structure is removed.

The SOP provides for the use of drone-based inspections where needed to enhance surveillance capabilities. Field operations are also being integrated with the Vacant Land Monitoring System, which will be regularly updated with land records, verification of vacant plots after demolition, and continuous monitoring of cleared sites to prevent re-encroachment. This integration addresses one of the persistent problems in urban land management in Delhi, where land cleared of encroachments is frequently re-encroached upon if not actively monitored.



The SOP follows directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who had chaired a meeting of the DDA Advisory Council and directed a strict zero-tolerance approach to encroachment anywhere in the capital.

The Flying Squad Teams will conduct regular field inspections across their entire jurisdictions, identify unauthorised constructions and encroachments at an early stage, determine the ownership and legal status of the land involved, and document violations through geo-tagged photographs with date and time stamps.

These reports will be submitted for immediate enforcement action. Where required, demolition must be carried out within 72 hours of detection.

The quick response teams will carry out prompt demolition and removal operations upon identification of violations and completion of required legal procedures.

Their specific obligations under the SOP include submitting a demolition report with geo-tagged before-and-after photographs by the end of the same day the demolition is carried out, undertaking videography of the demolition exercise where required, and fixing the DDA ownership board at every site from which an unautho-

The framework also covers ongoing unauthorised construction on private land falling within development areas, which will be demolished after following due process of law. The SOP clearly delineates responsibilities among the DDA's Land Management, Engineering, and Horticulture Departments to strengthen inter-departmental coordination and fix accountability.

The LG's direction for zero-tolerance on encroachments comes in the context of a broader enforcement drive that has been running across Delhi since the June 3 Malviya Nagar hotel fire exposed the scale of unauthorised construction in the city's commercial and residential zones.

Since June 1, the MCD has demolished 97 properties and sealed 126 others across all municipal zones. The DDA's new SOP extends this enforcement framework specifically to DDA and government-owned land, adding institutional structure to what has until now been a more ad-hoc response to individual encroachment complaints. The significance of the 72-hour demolition timeline is that it imposes a defined operational deadline on enforcement teams rather than allowing detection to be followed by indefinite delays before action.



A hazy view of the Kartavya Path on a summer day in New Delhi

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Delhi air quality hits 261, enters poor category

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's daily average Air Quality Index crossed 200 and reached 261 in the Poor category at 4 pm on Sunday, prompting the Commission for Air Quality Management's GRAP Sub-Committee to convene an emergency review meeting.

The meeting concluded that the deterioration was caused by long-range transboundary mineral dust transport from a storm originating near Afghanistan, Iran, and Pakistan, and decided not to invoke GRAP Stage-I restrictions as a result.

The CAQM Sub-Committee, after reviewing the current air quality data from CPCB and meteorological forecasts from

IMD and the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology, determined that the current spike is attributable to elevated atmospheric PM10 concentrations caused by the dust storm moving from northwestern India toward the Indo-Gangetic plain, including Delhi-NCR, driven by strong winds across the region.

Since the deterioration is caused by transboundary dust rather than local sources such as vehicular emissions, construction activity, or biomass burning, the sub-committee decided that invoking GRAP Stage-I, which places restrictions on local pollution-generating activities, would not be the appropriate response to this particular episode.

Harry Boxer gang module busted in Rohini

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

A man released from judicial custody on May 29 after being arrested in a 2024 murder case had, within days of walking free.

He re-established contact with the Harry Boxer gang through encrypted apps, recruited two shooters from his native village in Azamgarh, Uttar Pradesh, arranged three sophisticated pistols buried underground near a drain in Rohini's Sector 11 and 25 area, and was waiting only for final instructions from gang handlers to carry out targeted killings of businessmen across Delhi-NCR when police arrested him and his two associates on July 8 and 9, foiling what investigators say was a conspiracy that had reached its final stage of execution.

DCP Rohini District Shashank Jaiswal confirmed that three alleged shooters of the Harry Boxer gang have been arrested and three sophisticated illegal pistols, including a 9 mm pistol and a Beretta pistol, along with 26 live cartridges and a Hero Deluxe motorcycle have been recovered.

"The timely intervention, meticulous investigation and proactive policing by Rohini District Police pre-



vented a major gangland crime and ensured the safety of the targeted businessmen," Jaiswal said.

The case originated on March 8, 2026, when a businessman approached the North Rohini police station reporting extortion calls received from foreign numbers between March 6 and March 8. The caller identified himself as Randeep Malik, claimed association with the Harry Boxer gang, demanded ₹1 crore, and threatened to kill the complainant if payment was not made. The complainant preserved call recordings and screenshots, which proved crucial to the investigation.

The threat escalated dramatically on July 4, when the complainant received a WhatsApp call along with photographs and videos of his own residence. The caller this time introduced himself as Harry Boxer and informed the complainant that recon-

naissance of his house had already been completed.

He said that if the extortion demand was not met, either the complainant or a family member would be murdered. Investigators used technical surveillance, human intelligence, CCTV analysis covering the preceding 15 days around the complainant's residence, and digital forensic examination of encrypted communications to identify the suspects. The trail led to Shiv Govind, 19, from Tughlakabad Village in Delhi, who was arrested from Srinivaspuri.

His mobile phone contained photographs and videos of the complainant's residence and photographs of jewellery establishments in Karol Bagh. The data showed these files had been transmitted to gang handlers through Signal.

Interrogation and further surveillance led to the arrest

of Abhinav alias Akash Singh, 23, from Azamgarh on July 8, and through him, to Vivek, 22, also from Azamgarh.

Abhinav's profile is the most alarming detail in the case. He had been arrested in the 2024 murder of gym owner Nadir Shah at Greater Kailash-I, a sensational case at the time. He was released from judicial custody on May 29, 2026. Within days he had re-established contact with the Harry Boxer gang. He then recruited Vivek from Azamgarh as a shooter and directed Shiv Govind to conduct reconnaissance of the complainant's residence in Rohini and targeted jewellery establishments in Karol Bagh. The firearms used for the planned killings had been supplied by one Anil Pandit, stated to be based in the United States, and were buried underground near the Sector 11 to 25 drain area in Rohini to avoid police detection.

The three accused had travelled from Azamgarh to Delhi and stayed in different hotels across the city to conceal their movements.

They were not only targeting the original complainant but conducting reconnaissance of multiple businessmen's residences across Delhi-NCR and identifying additional victims for planned assassinations.

After 15 years, Delhi zoo hatches three spectacled cobras via artificial incubation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After nearly 15 years, the National Zoological Park in Delhi has successfully bred three spectacled cobra hatchlings, marking a major achievement in reptile conservation and scientific animal management efforts.

The three hatchlings emerged between June 29 and 30 after a successful incubation period under the supervision of the zoo's veterinary and animal care teams, Zoo Director Sanjeet Kumar said on Sunday.

The development comes after years of unsuccessful attempts to breed the

species, he said.

"The cobra eggs were kept in an artificial incubation chamber where machines helped maintain the required temperature and humidity levels," Kumar said.

The hatchlings are healthy, active and have been shifted to a secure enclosure with a species-specific environment, he said, adding that they are being continuously monitored. According to him, a controlled environment is necessary until they mature, as even minor variations in conditions could affect the hatchlings.

The zoo had earlier recorded successful breeding of spectacled cobras during

2010-11, when 11 hatchlings were born. However, no successful hatching was reported for several years after that, making the recent achievement significant.

The director said eggs of reptiles such as spectacled cobras, monitor lizards and pythons are regularly collected and incubated at the zoo. According to a zoo official, they opt for artificial incubation of the eggs to ensure successful breeding, as naturally laid eggs were either consumed by the reptiles themselves or attacked by birds such as crows.

Two interns under the zoo's internship programme are also involved in reptile



Cobra hatchling at Delhi Zoo after artificial incubation

PTI

behaviour and biological studies, including incubation-related work, he added.

At present, the National Zoological Park has three adult spectacled cobras in its

collection — two males and one female.

He said the achievement will help strengthen scientific understanding and conservation efforts for reptiles.

The spectacled cobra, or Naja naja, is a species of venomous snake native to the Indian sub-continent. The species gets its name from a striking, dark pattern on the back of its hood that resembles a pair of glasses.

The species is protected under the Indian Wildlife Protection Act to prevent exploitation from the skin trade and snake charmers, reduce human-wildlife conflict and maintain ecological balance.

DELHI ZOO LAUNCHES BUTTERFLY, DRAGONFLY WALK UNDER CITIZEN SCIENCE INITIATIVE

New Delhi: The National Zoological Park (NZP) here on Sunday launched a new citizen science initiative, with 21 participants documenting 12 butterfly species, seven dragonfly species and three damselfly species during the inaugural walk.

The initiative, 'Sunday Butterfly and Dragonfly Walk at NZP' was held from 7 am to 10 am and was led by naturalist and wildlife photographer Ramveer, along with volunteers. The walk saw participation from

butterfly enthusiasts, students, wildlife photographers and nature lovers, a statement said.

Participants recorded observations of more than 500 butterflies, dragonflies and damselflies across the zoological park, popularly known as Delhi zoo, it said.

The initiative aims to encourage citizens to contribute to documenting insect diversity while learning scientific methods of species identification, observation and biodiversity data recording, it added. (PNS)

IN FOCUS



Workers fix the dome and give final touches ahead of the 'Rath Yatra' festival, near the Jagannath Temple, in Puri, Odisha on Sunday

PTI

BRICS delegates visit Tadoba reserve, spot multiple tigers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

A high-level delegation comprising ministers and senior officials from BRICS countries visited the Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve (TATR) in Maharashtra's Chandrapur district on Sunday and had multiple tiger sightings, officials said.

Transport ministers, heads of delegation, senior officials and delegates from member countries were in Nagpur for the third BRICS transport ministers' meeting under India's BRICS chairship, which began on July 9 and concluded on July 12. A release issued by the TATR field director said that more than 20 safari vehicles were deployed from the Kolara, Madnapur and Belara buffer gates to facilitate the visit of the 70-member BRICS delegation.

During the morning safari, delegates from Russia and Ethiopia sighted the well-known tiger T-178 along with a sub-adult offspring of tigress T-82, the release said. In the evening safari, delegates from South Africa, Egypt and Iran had sightings of T-



178, a sub-adult of T-82 and a sub-adult of TN-9, it added. The delegates also observed a rich diversity of wildlife, including chital, sambar, Indian gaur, wild boar, and numerous bird species amid the lush green forests rejuvenated by the monsoon rains, it said.

According to the release, the delegates expressed their appreciation for the "exceptional safari experience" and commended the scientific management and conservation practices adopted by the reserve.

The visit was coordinated by the leadership and field staff of TATR. Field Director Prabhu Nath Shukla and Deputy Director Vishal Mali led the reserve team, it added.

Iran hits back after US strikes, Gulf on alert

Meanwhile, missile alerts sounded in Bahrain, an island kingdom in the Persian Gulf home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet. Kuwait's military also said it was intercepting incoming fire.

The Omani state news agency said drones struck sites in an area that sits on the Strait of Hormuz and issued a shelter-in-place warning for residents in the region.

The attack came after the two countries held talks on Saturday. Oman summoned the Iranian ambassador to protest the strikes.

Three Iranian missiles struck areas across Jordan, causing minor damage but no injuries, Jordan's state news agency reported.

Sirens also sounded in the United Arab Emirates, but the Government said missiles did not cross into UAE borders. The UAE so far hasn't been targeted in the most recent round of Iranian attacks. In the Strait of Hormuz attack, a Cyprus-flagged container ship was hit by Iran and suffered "significant engineering damage", the US Central Command said early Sunday morning.

Oman's maritime authority said it rescued 23 crew members from the ship, but that one is still missing. India's Ministry of External Affairs said the missing crew member is an Indian national and said it was working with Oman to locate him. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre, overseen by the British military, said the ship had been hugging the shoreline of Oman. That's been the way ships have entered and exited the Persian Gulf while avoiding Iranian territorial waters.

Iran has sought to maintain control over transit through the strait during the 60-day ceasefire. Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard said multiple vessels "disregarded our warnings" and ignored instructions to follow what it called an approved route. One of them "was struck by a warning shot and brought to a stop".

Iran said that the strait would remain closed "until further notice" and said it would consider targeting "additional enemy bases in the region" if it faced more attacks.

Iranian state media reported US strikes across the country, including southern Iran in the province closest to the Strait of Hormuz, and military sites in a province near Tehran.

The latest violence followed Iran and Oman's foreign ministers meeting on Saturday to discuss the strait. The narrow strait sits in both Iran and Oman's territorial waters, but has long been considered an international waterway.

Oman said it and Iran agreed to continue discussing the Strait of Hormuz "at the technical and political levels." However, Iran offered no statement about the strait being open to all - something sought by the Trump administration.

US President Donald Trump suggested last week that the interim deal in the Iran war was "over". But mediators, including Pakistan, Qatar

Ram temple trust to define first CEO's powers: Nripendra Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ayodhya

Nripendra Mishra, chairman of the Ram Temple Construction Committee, said on Sunday that the trust will decide the duties and powers of the first Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Ayodhya temple. He said the CEO's main job is to maintain devotees' faith in the trust.

Mishra told reporters in Ayodhya that the new CEO will also handle financial matters. He added that the Government will not interfere with how the trust or its CEO works.

Since the temple was consecrated in January 2024, many visitors have come to Ayodhya. To handle this, the trust is appointing a CEO to help run things more smoothly. Mishra said the trust board will clearly define the CEO's role so that decisions match the temple's spiritual values. He emphasised that the main goal is to protect and strengthen devotees' faith.

The CEO will ensure 'Darshan' runs smoothly, keep the temple premises sacred, and help pilgrims have a good experience year-round. Managing the temple's finances is also a key part of the job. The temple gets large donations from devotees in India and abroad, so handling these funds openly and efficiently is important for maintaining the temple, improving facilities for pilgrims, and finishing the



remaining construction work.

Mishra's statement that there is no Government interference demonstrates the trust's independence. The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is a religious group established to manage the temple in accordance with tradition and devotees' wishes. By keeping control within the trust, they want to keep daily operations free from outside bureaucracy. Managing crowds, security, medical help, and basic services has become very important.

The CEO will manage these operations with guidance from the trust board. Mishra, who has been closely involved with the temple project, said the trust is still focused on its main goal of serving Lord Ram and His devotees. Appointing a CEO is seen as a practical way to handle more activities while

keeping the temple's devotional spirit.

Observers believe this step will make the temple's operations more accountable and professional, while the trust's leaders will still make the main policy decisions. The CEO will follow the trust's rules to make sure finances, services for devotees, and administration are managed well and openly. Ayodhya continues to attract pilgrims from all over India and the world.

The trust's focus on faith-centric management is expected to further strengthen the bond between the temple and its devotees. Mishra's statement on Sunday has been welcomed by many as a clear signal that the Ram Temple will continue to be run as a sacred institution, free from external control and dedicated solely to upholding the faith of millions.

NHAI refutes Akhilesh claim that Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway caved in before opening

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday alleged that the Rs 4,700 crore Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway, which is scheduled to be inaugurated the next day, had caved in before its opening.

The National Highways Authority of India has rejected the claim, stating that the expressway is constructed in accordance with all the prescribed quality standards and is completely safe, while the BJP accused Yadav of making baseless statements on development projects to stay relevant.

According to the official announcement, Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari, and



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath are scheduled to inaugurate the Kanpur-Lucknow Expressway from Unnao at 3 pm on Monday.

In an X post on Sunday, Yadav attacked the BJP over the condition of major expressway projects, alleging corruption in their construction and questioning their safety and design.

Expressways are meant

to enable people to travel quickly and without worry, and "not to spend the entire journey praying to God", he said in the post.

He further alleged that the Rs 4,700-crore Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway had caved in before its inauguration. He also cited the Rs 6,700-crore Missing Link project in Maharashtra, claiming that its condition has exposed corruption and

brought disrepute to the BJP government.

"Is there a competition of mega corruption in BJP-ruled states?" Yadav asked, while also taking a swipe at the designers of the two projects.

The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister asked whether the Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway was designed for public convenience or to benefit contractors linked to the BJP.

He claimed that commuters would spend more time entering the city from the Expressway than travelling between the two cities.

"If this continues because of corruption, a traveller will think 40 times before setting out on a 40-minute journey. Speed has no meaning if it is not safe," he said.

Reacting to Yadav's allegations, the National Highways Authority of India's (NHAI)

Project Director Nakul Prakash Verma asserted that there was no subsidence anywhere on the project.

"Where has it caved in? It has not caved in anywhere," Verma said, adding that the Expressway would be opened to the public from 8 am on July 14.

"Once the Expressway is opened, the truth will become evident. If I am wrong, the public itself will expose it," he said.

Verma said the photographs of subsidence being circulated on social media were not of the main carriageway but of the roadside earthen embankment, describing it as a routine maintenance matter.

"When it rains, some soil gets washed away, and fresh soil is filled in again. This is called a 'rain cut', and it is common on highways. A

road caving in is a different issue, while erosion of roadside soil is entirely different," he explained, assuring that the erosion had not affected the structural integrity of the Expressway or the safety of traffic.

According to Verma, the affected portion has already been repaired, and all necessary technical works will be completed before the Expressway is inaugurated.

He asserted that the Expressway is completely safe and has been constructed in accordance with all prescribed quality standards.

The BJP too has reacted to the Samajwadi Party chief's claim. BJP's Unnao district president Anurag Awasthi dismissed the allegations as baseless, stating that the opposition was making unnecessary statements over development projects.



No need to wear your faith on your sleeve, says ex-BJP leader Annamalai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Coimbatore

Former BJP Tamil Nadu President K Annamalai on Sunday asserted that a true Hindu treats everyone equally and embraces everyone and does not regard someone as high or low.

Addressing his foundation's first conference at Pollachi near here, Annamalai said he is a proud nationalist and Indian.

Annamalai helmed "We The Leaders" foundation chose a stand against drugs as its theme for its first rally here.

He said: "I am a Hindu, but when I step out, I lock up my caste and religion inside my house. There is no need to highlight and display religion every-time."

Furthermore, Annamalai said: "True Hindu treats all equally, he does not talk that one is superior and that another is inferior. He will say that everyone must go together in a straight line. That is my Hindu philosophy."

On the recent Tamil Nadu Assembly polls, he said that those below 39 years of age brought about the regime change.

C Joseph Vijay-led TVK, floated in 2024 assumed power emerging as the single largest party in the 2026 TN Assembly polls.

Similarly, in 2031, when Assembly polls are next due,

young people belonging to such a young age bracket will bring a very big regime change, he said.

Nobody should be forced to join the movement, he said adding participation should be voluntary based on the work done.

During the next six months, six important issues would be taken up to create awareness including environment, he noted.

Six resolutions were passed in the anti-drug awareness conference that were against drugs, alcohol dependence and abuse.

A resolution slammed alleged lax implementation of norms governing functioning of "FL2" category clubs that serve alcoholic beverages to its members.

According to the organisers, every July will be observed as "White band month" to take a pledge to stay away from drugs and help others to do so.

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duced with an aim to ensure that Governments are not run from jail. If the recommendations are accepted, the Ministry of Home Affairs will approach the Union Cabinet with the proposed amendments and later bring official amendments in the Lok Sabha.

Forensics deepen Twisha Sharma death probe

Twisha married Bhopal lawyer Samarth Singh in December 2025 after meeting him on a dating app. She was found hanging at their home in Bhopal's Katara Hills on May 12, 2026, just five months later.

According to the FIR, Samarth said he found Twisha hanging around 10:20 pm and took her to AIIMS Bhopal, where doctors declared her dead on arrival.

Her family tells a different story: at 9:41 pm, Twisha was on a call with her mother when shouting was heard, and then the call ended. After that, calls went unanswered until her mother-in-law, retired district judge Giribala Singh, answered and reportedly said, "She is no more," before hanging up.

Twisha's family, which includes members of the armed forces, has repeatedly accused Samarth and Giribala of dowry-related harassment, mental and physical abuse, and domestic violence. The CBI FIR also notes claims that the mother-in-law demanded a 72 lakh dowry and refused to give Twisha money for her personal needs. The in-laws deny all these accusations, saying Twisha made her own decisions and struggled with mental health issues that led to suicide. The first post-mortem at AIIMS Bhopal found that Twisha died from "antemortem hanging by ligature" and showed signs of asphyxia, such as facial congestion, petechial haemorrhages, and Tardieu's spots in the lungs. The report also listed several blunt-force injuries before death: abrasions on the left side of her neck, bruises on her left upper arm and forearm, right wrist, right ring finger, and a 2 cm by 2 cm bruise under the scalp in the left frontoparietal area. Two small bruised patches were also found in the tissue beneath the ligature mark.

The Madhya Pradesh High Court, noting problems in the case, ordered a second autopsy by experts from AIIMS Delhi and later handed the investigation to the CBI. Samarth was arrested on May 22 after reportedly fleeing, and Giribala's anticipatory bail was cancelled before she was arrested on May 28. Both are still in judicial custody. The CBI has recreated the crime scene at the Katara Hills home using dummies. The new AIIMS report is a key piece of evidence, confirming that this specific belt touched her neck in a way that matches her injuries.

However, the report does not answer the main question: whether Twisha used the belt herself in a moment of despair or someone else used

it on her. The short time between her distressed phone call and when her body was found, along with her earlier injuries, keeps her family suspicious. As the CBI reviews the sealed report along with digital evidence, call records, and witness statements, the case highlights common problems in Indian dowry-death investigations. It is often hard to tell the difference between abetment or murder and suicide when there are no direct witnesses, and forensic evidence needs more proof to show criminal intent.

For Twisha's family, the AIIMS findings provide the scientific proof they have been seeking. For the accused and investigators, the findings are another piece of evidence in an investigation that still needs to clearly show what happened in Twisha's final minutes on May 12. The gymnastics belt is now forensically linked to her fatal injuries, but it is still unclear who used it and why.

Parliament braces for showdown as Govt...

In addition, three Trinamool MPs resigned from the Rajya Sabha before joining the BJP. The Shiv Sena (UBT) has also witnessed another split, with six of its Lok Sabha MPs joining the Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde. Earlier, seven AAP members of the Rajya Sabha had also joined the BJP.

West Bengal's new rulebook

Referring to CM's instruction a senior officer of the State police department on Sunday said, "All the district police administrations have been notified about it. The laws will be enforced from tomorrow." Modeled after laws prevalent in States like Uttar Pradesh the first law stipulates the preventive detention for 12 months without trial. The second law proposes confiscation of the properties of those who destroy public property. A Claims Commission will determine the amount of compensation.

Former State BJP president and Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar on Sunday said, "Bengal had enough of unruliness in the name of protests. It is necessary to take the State towards the path of development. Preventive detention by the police on suspicion of mischief is one of the measures that can ensure a better law and order."

Opposition Left and Congress have strongly objected to the implementation of what they called draconian laws. CPI(M) central committee member Meenakshi Mukherjee said, "These laws are clearly aimed against the political opponents who would rise up to protest against anti-people measures taken by this Government. First, they will unleash bulldozers on hapless poor demolishing their shops and houses and if they protest they will be arrested. They will also not

allow the arrested persons lawyers of their choice. They will have to appoint lawyers from the State panel. The BJP is digging its own grave." Congress leader Adhir Chowdhury compared the law with Rowlatt Act saying, "The democratic minded people of West Bengal will definitely protest against such laws."

Vietnam tragedy victims begin journey home

"We continue to pray for the early recovery of the one survivor at Phu Quoc Hospital," it added.

Of the 15 victims, 10 were from Tamil Nadu, three were from Andhra Pradesh and two were from Kerala. Two of the deceased were women, according to a list shared by the embassy.

According to the list, the deceased from Tamil Nadu were identified as Senthil Kumar Jayavel, Muruga Prabhu Arumugam, Sridhar Sundararajan, Shaik Abdullah Abdul Majeed, Balaji Natesan, Vinaya Kumar Chithirapuram Bhaskara, Ravisankar Sugumaran, Santosh Kumar Shantillal Jain, Babu Kuppuswamy and Alagurajan Sivasamy.

The deceased from Andhra Pradesh were identified as Nallapeta Adiseshaiah Raviteja, Sreedhar Mudiam and Jaya Lakshmi Gelli, while those from Kerala were identified as Avicot Cherian Thomas and Loveni Thomas.

The Governments in the three southern states have issued helpline numbers to assist relatives of the affected persons.

Earlier on Sunday, the Indian Embassy in Hanoi said 16 of the 17 surviving tourists were discharged from the hospital and were on their way to India. "After obtaining medical treatment, 15 survivors of yesterday's tragic boat accident have been discharged from hospital and are travelling back to India," the embassy said in a separate post on X.

"Of the two patients in critical care, one has been discharged and is travelling back to India. The other is undergoing treatment at a hospital in Phu Quoc," it said. Phu Quoc, Vietnam's largest island, is a major tourist destination known for its white-sand beaches, coral reefs and island-hopping excursions.

The tourists were reportedly returning from an island visit when their speedboat capsized about 400 metres off Hon May Rut Ngaoi island.

Nearby tourist boats reportedly rushed to pull passengers from the water before border guards, the navy, the coast guard and other forces joined the search-and-rescue operation. Eyewitnesses told the local media that some of the passengers were trapped inside the overturned speedboat, which made rescue difficult.

The exact cause of the incident is yet to be ascertained. Vietnamese Prime Minister Le Minh Hung has ordered an investigation into the cause of the accident and directed authorities to hold those responsible accountable, local media reported.

GRAPEVINE

Upar Wala Sab Dekhta Hai

A lot of guesswork and the rumour mill have been working on the sudden removal and termination of the entire personal staff of a prominent Union Minister. But grapevine from the Sewa Teerth has emanated that the links are connected elsewhere, hence demanding immediate action against the officials who were privy to preliminary rounds of discussion on a fruitful developmental project in a State. The matter was leaked by one of them about the 'surreptitious' deliberations. The first to face music in this regard was a big industrialist and a prominent business house whose offices were raided by agencies across several parts of the country nearly a month ago. Subsequently, an internal enquiry was done, and on a single day, separate office orders announced the termination of services of all four government officials of this high-profile ministry.



Extension business versus contract officers

The 'contractual' extension of the Central Board of Direct Taxes head has recently raised eyebrows, as this is the first time such an arrangement has been made in the department's history. As per the Government's appointment orders, he was reappointed for one year on a contract basis. Several in the bureaucracy have doubted the legality of such extensions and wonder why the Government has been 'promoting' such contractual engagements to head very crucial departments. While a few top bureaucrats argue that a proper extension of service is more accountable, the grapevine has it that certain people and forums are planning to challenge this kind of extension-giving method in governance before the courts.



Veteran journalist on reshuffle news

Recently, a veteran journalist gave advice to media colleagues on writing about the chances of a Cabinet reshuffle. He said that in every democratic country, normally before the Parliament Session or after the Session, speculative reports about a possible Cabinet reshuffle will emerge. In India too, such news reports start flowing in, and reams are written and said about such speculations, but when their predictions get weak, then these reports are spiced with materials of auspicious and inauspicious months and days. "Holi, Diwali, Hindu New Year, Sawan, Pitru Paksha speculations and plants are more read on speculations of Cabinet reshuffles," quipped the veteran journalist who himself was part of the Government once upon a time.



VP lauds social reformer Mannathu Padmanabhan's contributions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday lauded the contributions of eminent social reformer, freedom fighter and founder of the Nair Service Society (NSS).

Mannathu Padmanabhan, saying he dedicated his life to the upliftment of society through various reforms and service.

Unveiling the statue of Padmanabhan and inaugurating the Mannam Smriti Mandapam in Delhi, the vice president also appreciated the work undertaken by the Delhi unit of the NSS in preserving Kerala's rich cultural heritage in the national Capital.

The eminent social reformer, freedom fighter and founder of the NSS dedicated his life to the upliftment of society through edu-

cation, social reform, self-reliance and community service, Radhakrishnan said.

Describing Padmanabhan as a true leader of community renaissance, the vice president said that his vision extended far beyond sectional interests.

"He believed that every human being deserved equal dignity and equal opportunity. His life's work reminds us that genuine social progress is possible only when justice, compassion and inclusiveness become the guiding principles of society," he said.

Radhakrishnan said the remarkable growth of the NSS itself bears testimony to the extraordinary dedication and determination of its founder.

He said that Padmanabhan firmly believed that great institutions were built not by great wealth, but by great commit-

Ambala bomb blast: NIA names Pak handler, 7 Indians

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has filed a chargesheet against Pakistani terrorist Shehzad Bhatti and seven Indian nationals in connection with the car bomb blast at Ambala's Baldev Nagar police station. The agency presented the chargesheet to the Special NIA Court in Panchkula. Bhatti, who is a wanted gangster-turned-terrorist based in Pakistan, has been identified as the main conspirator.

The seven Indian accused are Karamjit Singh, also known as Tony; Akash; Soureb, also known as Sobi or Sourab; Raman Kumar;

Satyam; Sukhdev Singh, also known as Sukha; and Amarjeet Singh, also known as Ambi. All eight have been charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Explosive Substances Act, and the Telecommunication Act. According to the chargesheet, the conspiracy was meant to attack a police station and create fear among the public.

NIA investigators say Bhatti directed the operation from Pakistan. He is accused of setting up groups inside India and giving local operatives the job of carrying out the attack. Akash has been named Bhatti's main coordinator in India, handling logistics, com-



munication, and execution. The investigation found that the Baldev Nagar police station was chosen as the

target after checking several possible locations.

The chargesheet says some of the accused parked a

NIA arrests two key absconders in Praveen Nettaru murder case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) arrested two key absconding suspects in one of Karnataka's major political murder cases on Saturday. Abdul Nasir P, also known as Nasir, was caught in Kochi, Kerala, and Naushad was arrested in Hosur, Tamil Nadu. The operation was planned and carried out in two states after the Andhra Pradesh police provided actionable intelligence.

These arrests bring the total number of people in custody for the 2022 murder of BJP leader Praveen Nettaru to 25. Three suspects are still on the run. The NIA said both men had already been chargesheeted in the case (RC-36/2022/NIA/DLI) for knowingly helping the main attackers.

It may be recalled that Praveen Nettaru, a District Executive Committee member of the BJP Yuva Morcha in Dakshina Kannada, was killed in a targeted attack in 2022. During the course of the investiga-



tion, the NIA found that members of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) were behind the murder. The agency had already invoked sections of the Indian Penal Code and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act against those named in the chargesheet, including the two men who were just arrested.

Before these arrests, the NIA Special Court in Bengaluru had issued a Look Out Circular (LOC) and an open-ended warrant for both men. The agency also offered a reward of ₹4,00,000 for information leading to each arrest. This operation shows how well

central and state agencies can work together and share information quickly.

These arrests are an important step toward accountability in a case that caused widespread anger in coastal Karnataka. The NIA said it is still working to find and arrest the remaining three suspects. The agency also reiterated its promise to fully investigate every aspect of the case, including the conspiracy and those who aided the attackers.

By arresting two more suspects, the agency has strengthened its case. The Praveen Nettaru murder case is still being closely watched, and investigators are now working to gather

more evidence for the trial and bring the remaining suspects to court as soon as possible.

For the family of the victim, for Praveen Nettaru's family and the people of Dakshina Kannada, each arrest brings some closure and helps restore trust in the justice system. As the investigation continues, the main goal is to uncover the full conspiracy and make sure everyone responsible for the killing is convicted, said an official. The NIA has appealed to the public to share any information about the remaining absconders, as sustained pressure from law enforcement agencies continues.



ment. Recalling how he accepted even humble contributions from ordinary households to establish educational and social institutions, the vice president said these collective efforts transformed

the lives of generations.

Radhakrishnan expressed happiness that, more than a century after its establishment, the ideals of Padmanabhan have spread far beyond Kerala.

Wayanad landslide: BJP slams Rahul, Priyanka for absence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday criticised Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra for their absence from Wayanad, where a landslide left eight people dead, alleging that they are "part-time politicians" who have used the constituency for their political survival.

The landslide occurred on July 7 at the site of the Anakkampoyil-Meppadi twin-tube tunnel project, which is intended to connect Wayanad and Kozhikode districts.

BJP national spokesperson Tuhin Sinha accused Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, the current MP from Wayanad, and Rahul Gandhi, who represented the Lok Sabha seat earlier, of failing to reach out to the affected families.

"They are merely political tourists. Apart from a single



BJP national spokesperson Tuhin Sinha

condolence post on social media, neither of them has shown any interest in reaching out to the affected families. This is shameful and reflects that both of them are part-time politicians," he said.

"Neither Priyanka Gandhi Vadra nor Rahul Gandhi found the time to visit the constituency. This is the second major landslide after

the one in July 2024, which claimed several hundred lives. Even then, Rahul Gandhi arrived late, and now neither of them has deemed it necessary to visit the affected area," he added.

Sinha alleged that the Congress leaders have treated Wayanad as a "constituency of political convenience."

Govt aims to establish Haryana as knowledge economy hub: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hissar

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said the Government aims to establish the State as a knowledge economy hub.

To achieve this objective, the State's education ecosystem is being reshaped on the principles of 'Re-design, Re-imagine and Re-invest'. Under this vision, comprehensive reforms in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) have been implemented across state universities and their affiliated colleges.

The chief minister was addressing a function at Guru Jambheshwar University of Science and Technology (GJUST), Hissar. He inaugurated and laid the foundation stone of projects worth ₹7.58 crore. These included the foundation stone of a girls' hostel to be



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini

constructed at a cost of ₹6 crore and the inauguration of the nursing department building constructed at a cost of ₹1.40 crore.

Saini said that Guru Jambheshwar University has set an exemplary benchmark in the effective implementation of the NEP. He said that the youth have high expectations from institutions such as this university. These institutions should emerge as centres of research and innovation, serving as a bridge between local industries and global technologies.

India declares one day national mourning for former Qatar Emir

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India declared a one-day national mourning on Monday as a mark of respect for former Emir of Qatar Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al-Thani with Prime Minister Narendra Modi describing him as a "visionary leader".

Sheikh Hamad, known as the Father Emir of Qatar, passed away this morning at the age of 74. He ruled Qatar from 1995 to 2013 and is credited with ushering in socio-economic development in the energy-rich Gulf nation.

He also played a key role in deepening India-Qatar relations.

"We feel profound sadness at the death of the Father Emir of the State of Qatar, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa Al Thani," PM Modi said on social media.



"He was a visionary leader who guided Qatar to great levels of development and prosperity. We also remember him as a true friend whom I had the honour of meeting during my last visit to Qatar in February 2024," he said.

The prime minister extended his "sincerest

financing, the procurement of explosives, and operational coordination under Bhatti's direction.

Haryana Police first handled the case, but it was later given to the NIA due to suspected cross-border terror links. The agency built its case against the eight accused through searches, forensic analysis, and checking digital records.

The filing of the chargesheet marks a major step in the investigation. All the accused will now go on trial in the special NIA court in Panchkula. NIA officials say the investigation is still ongoing to find more conspirators or wider network links connected to the case.



Abhishek Banerjee booked for medical lapse at health camp

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

There are more problems for Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, the nephew of former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

A woman who lost her legs during treatment at Sebasraay health camp, a much-touted healthcare outreach initiative set up by the TMC MP, has lodged a police complaint against the leader, saying she was cheated and defrauded in the name of giving free treatment.

One Prabir Biswas, husband of Malati Biswas, the victim, lodged a police complaint a couple of days ago stating his wife's leg had to be amputated due to medical negligence. The police have drawn an FIR based on the complaint.

It has been stated in the complaint that Biswas was prodded by a TMC councillor to attend the health camp. "She had pain in her legs... they prescribed medicines, but it did not heal... the specialist doctors did not look like those... at most they looked like medical students... after several visits we were referred to Government hospital where operation was conducted on my wife's legs... the surgery went wrong, and her leg had to be amputated."

An official at the Rabindranagar police station said that an FIR had been registered against Banerjee and some other persons, and investigations were on.

The Diamond Harbour MP had unveiled the Sebaashray initiative, coined the "Diamond Harbour Model" last year and set up several camps wherein prospective patients (read: villagers) were

invited to get free health check-ups before the elections.

According to the police, at least three similar FIRs have been lodged by different parties who complained that "musclemen of notorious local TMC leader of Falta Jahangir Khan were appointed to forcibly bring the people to the camp. 'I had no issues but was forced to attend the health camp... they conducted various tests, but reports would never arrive,' said another patient.

Several senior government doctors from various medical colleges presently up in arms against Banerjee have confirmed the subject matter of the complaints lodged against Banerjee, saying they were under constant pressure of being transferred to remote areas should they not send junior doctors and even students feigning them as specialist doctors.

The TMC MP, who could not be contacted for his reaction to the FIRs, was already in trouble, facing charges of issuing public threats against the BJP workers after the elections. In one such case, Banerjee has been issued bail by the High Court on the condition that he would cooperate with the police by giving his voice samples.

Banerjee had been heard during a public campaign threatening the BJP workers with dire consequences after they returned to power post May 4, when the results would come out. "Mamata Banerjee is compassionate... so she plays Rabindra Sangeet... but I am not... we will play DJ along with Rabindra Sangeet after election results are out on May 4," he said.

■ States Focus ■



MEHBOOBA MUFTI UNDER HOUSE ARREST AHEAD OF MARTYRS' DAY

Peoples Democratic Party chief Mehbooba Mufti has been placed under house arrest ahead of Martyrs' Day observance in Srinagar, her daughter Iltija Mufti claimed on Sunday. "We have been placed under house arrest on the eve of Martyrs' Day for reasons best known to J&K Police," Iltija posted on X. July 13 is commemorated as Martyrs' Day in Jammu and Kashmir as a tribute to 22 persons who were killed by the Dogra army outside Srinagar's central jail in 1931. The LG administration had dropped the day from the list of gazetted holidays in 2020. "This is the normalcy they claim to have established in Kashmir? Make no mistake, the local Government too is hand in glove using police in Sidhra to demolish homes and place opponents in detention when convenient," Iltija alleged. (PTI)



CISF DG REVIEWS SECURITY FOR AMARNATH PILGRIMS

CISF Director General Praveer Ranjan visited the Nunwan base camp at Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir to review the security arrangements for Amarnath pilgrims, a spokesman of the force said on Sunday. Ranjan accompanied by ADG, North, Sudhir Kumar visited Nunwan base camp on Saturday, to review the security arrangements for the ongoing Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra, the spokesman said. He said during the visit Director General (DG), Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) reviewed overall security arrangements, deployment plan, access control measures, communication network, surveillance systems, medical support, coordination mechanisms between CAPFs, J&K Police, civil administration, and other stakeholders. Ranjan inspected key deployment locations, check posts, communication centre CRPF, CCTV control room, and logistics arrangements. Special emphasis was laid on anti-sabotage measures, area domination, crowd management, route security, and preparedness to respond swiftly to any contingency, he said. The spokesman said the DG visited jawan barracks, pilgrim camps, met health workers and woman personnel. (PTI)

Nepal sends most foreign students to India: Survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nepal continues to send the largest number of students to India, while Karnataka is the top destination receiving the maximum foreign students, according to a Ministry of Education survey.

The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) for 2023-24 noted that India's higher education institutions attracted students from 173 countries in the 2023-24 academic year, with 58,134 foreign students enrolled across universities and colleges in the country.

The AISHE collects detailed information from higher education institu-

tions (HEIs) across the country through a web-based data capture format (DCF). Institutions upload data on student enrolment, faculty and staff, infrastructure, examination results, etc., on the AISHE portal.

The survey serves as the primary source of official statistics on higher education in India, providing critical insights for policy formulation, planning and monitoring of the sector.

In 2023-24, the highest share of foreign students came from Nepal (24.1 per cent), followed by the UAE (7 per cent), the US (5.9 per cent), Bangladesh (5.9 per cent), Nigeria (5.5 per cent) and Zimbabwe (4 per cent).



Representative image

PTI

The top 10 countries constituted 63.8 per cent of the total foreign students in 2023-24.

According to the report, Karnataka emerged as the top destination for international students, with 7,914

foreigners enrolled in its HEIs, narrowly ahead of Punjab (7,902).

Maharashtra (6,190), Uttar Pradesh (5,953) and Tamil Nadu (5,694) completed the top five list of hosting

foreign students. The highest number of foreign students was enrolled in undergraduate courses at 73.6 per cent, followed by post-graduate programmes at 16.8 per cent.

A total of 42,779 students were pursuing undergraduate programmes, accounting for nearly 74 per cent of the total. Of these, 27,849 were men and 14,930 women.

Another 9,845 students were enrolled in postgraduate programmes, while comparatively smaller numbers pursued diploma, PhD, certificate and integrated courses.

Foreign student enrolments rose from 48,898 in 2019-20 to 58,134 in 2023-24,

an increase of 9,236 students, or 18.9 per cent, over five years.

The growth was driven by both men and women students. While male enrolments increased from 32,386 to 37,295, the number of women students rose from 16,512 to 20,839 during the same period.

India also received foreign students from Lebanon, Burkina Faso, Mongolia, Mexico, Kazakhstan, Belarus and Chile, among others, in the 2023-24 academic year.

The Ministry of Education launched the Study in India (SII) programme in 2018 with an aim to attract international students to pursue higher education in India.

Amit Shah hails Gandhinagar's Guinness record in tree plantation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation, Amit Shah, who represents the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency, congratulated the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation, over 25,000 campaign volunteers, and the people of Gandhinagar for setting a Guinness World Record by planting more than 361,000 saplings in one hour using the Miyawaki method.

The Home Minister stated that, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, environmental conservation has become a nationwide movement. The '*Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam*' campaign has engaged millions of citizens in protecting nature. He noted that the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency has energised this effort by reaching a significant milestone in environmental conservation.

Shah emphasised that planting over 361,000 saplings in one hour using the Miyawaki technique demonstrates exceptional public participation, careful planning, and a strong commitment to environmental conservation. He congratulated the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation, the participating departments, voluntary organisations, volunteers, and the constituency on this achievement.

Residents of Gandhinagar planted over 12.6 million saplings as part of the Public Plantation Campaign. Of these, 11,593,513 were planted at 404 public sites, and more than 1.1 million were planted on private premises. The campaign covered multiple assembly constituencies, with detailed figures for each. This large-scale effort



stands as a model for public participation in environmental conservation.

Shah stated that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Progress with Nature" and sustainable development is being realised in the Gandhinagar Lok Sabha constituency through oxygen parks, large-scale tree plantations, pond restoration, and public campaigns. He added that Gandhinagar now serves as a national example in environmental protection and green development.

He said that tree plantation does not end with planting saplings; the protection and nurturing of these saplings are equally important. He emphasised that planting saplings is only the first step; their protection and care are equally important. He urged all citizens to join the '*Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam*' campaign, plant more trees, and take responsibility for nurturing them. He expressed confidence that public participation in such initiatives will help build a developed India and ensure a clean, green, and balanced environment for future generations.

BJP hails PM Modi's foreign tours, takes dig at Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday presented a 'report card' on the outcomes of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent foreign tours and criticised Rahul Gandhi, saying the prime minister returned having secured a victory for the country, while the Congress leader, who is abroad, must be "conspiring" behind closed doors.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters in New Delhi, party spokesperson Sambit Patra cited Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto's remarks that he adopted many of Modi's policies, and took a dig at Gandhi, saying if the Congress leader had emulated Modi "even a little bit", he would not have lost 99 elections.

Patra also took on the Congress and other Opposition parties, citing New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon's remarks acknowledging the transformation in India under Modi's leadership. "Just think what New



BJP spokesperson Sambit Patra

PTI

Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon said. And the Congress party in India refuses to accept it. I think our Opposition should also learn something," he said.

Patra highlighted various achievements of Modi's three-nation tour of Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand and said, "The prime minister went on a (foreign) tour and Rahul Gandhi too. The prime minister returned having brought victory to the nation, while Rahul Gandhi is surely conspiring behind closed doors."

Gandhi is likely "plotting" how to disrupt the good work being done under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, Patra charged further.

"You must be wondering where 'Rahul Baba' is. Go ahead, try to find out. A programme scheduled for him in Prayagraj on July 10 was postponed. There was an event in Patna as well; that too was postponed. There seem to be stamps on his passport from places like London, Iceland, and Germany, who knows? He is off on a tour," the BJP MP added.

Kerala to launch scheme to boost women's savings: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Sunday said his Government would launch a 'Pink Chitty' scheme through the KSFE to encourage women to save the money they benefit from free travel initiatives.

Speaking after inaugurating the Kochi Corporation's third roll-on/roll-off (Ro-Ro) vessel, Sethusagar-3, at the Vypeen boat jetty, Satheesan welcomed the civic body's decision to offer free travel for women on its Ro-Ro services. Earlier, the State Government introduced free travel for women on Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) ordinary buses across Kerala.

"The money women save through free travel should be set aside as their own savings. Women must have their own independent savings, which will help them live with



Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan

dignity and self-confidence. That is why the Government will take the initiative to introduce a 'Pink Chitty' through Kerala State Financial Enterprises (KSFE)", he said. He urged women not to part with their savings but to invest them in the proposed scheme.

Satheesan said the launch of the third Ro-Ro vessel would further strengthen Kochi's water transport

network and improve connectivity between Fort Kochi, Vypeen and Kochi city.

Describing Kochi as the first city in the country to introduce the Ro-Ro system, he said more such vessels would be added in the future to improve public transport.

The Chief Minister also outlined a series of infrastructure and tourism projects planned for Kochi, including a ₹190-crore, 190

MLD drinking water project to permanently address the city's water shortage.

He said work to renovate Fort Kochi beach would begin soon to boost tourism and announced plans to establish a 40-acre oceanarium at Puthuvypeen, a film city and an international-standard maritime museum.

"A major proposal to modernise Kochi's public transport system has also been submitted to the Centre. Kochi is on the verge of a major transformation," he said.

Kochi Mayor VK Minimol presided over the function.

MLAs Muhammed Shiyas, Tony Chammany, TJ Vinod and Deepak Joy, Kochi City Police Commissioner Kaliraj Mahesh Kumar, KSINC Managing Director R Girija, Cochin Smart Mission Limited CEO Arun N Nair, Cochin Shipyard CMD VJ Jose and other public representatives attended the event.

Jal Shakti Ministry to chair national water meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Jal Shakti will hold a conference of senior water resources secretaries from States and Union Territories on Monday to review key water sector initiatives and strengthen Centre-State coordination on reforms and implementation.

The conference, to be convened by the Department of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation under the Ministry of Jal Shakti at Sushma Swaraj Bhawan in New Delhi, aims to review the progress of the ministry's major national programmes and discuss priority initiatives in the water resources sector.

Key issues on the agenda include the modernisation of the Command Area Development and Water Management (M-CADWM)



Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil

scheme, the nationwide 'Catch the Rain' campaign, revised project appraisal guidelines, dam safety and State water reforms.

Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil will chair the conference. Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary and Secretary, Department of Water Resources, River Development and Ganga Rejuvenation, VL Kantha Rao, will co-chair it, according

to an official statement.

The conference will be attended by senior officials from the water resources departments of all States and Union Territories, as well as the Ministry of Jal Shakti, including its organisations, attached and subordinate offices, such as the Central Water Commission, the National Dam Safety Authority, and the National Water Mission.

Discussions will focus on

eight priority agenda items, including the status of the modernisation of the Command Area Development and Water Management (M-CADWM) scheme and the special one-month nationwide 'Catch the Rain' campaign aimed at strengthening people's participation in water conservation.

Other issues on the agenda include revised draft project appraisal guidelines for irrigation, multipurpose and flood management projects, rule curves of dam reservoirs and their effective implementation for improved reservoir operations and dam safety, the status of the State water reforms framework, completion of comprehensive dam safety evaluation under the Dam Safety Act, 2021 by December 2026, progress of irrigation censuses in States and Union Territories, and a framework for model State water awards.

BJP rejects Omar's bribe charge, asks him to introspect

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday criticised Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah over his accusation that it is trying to poach his National Conference party MLAs, saying that instead of making "speculative and baseless" claims, he should "introspect" on what kind of leaders he has in his party.

On Saturday, Abdullah accused the BJP of trying to bring down his Government in Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) by engineering a split in the ruling National Conference, claiming that his party MLAs were offered ₹20-30 crore to switch sides.

Addressing a packed workers' convention at the mausoleum of his grandparents at Hazratbal on the 26th death anniversary of his grandmother, Akbar Jehan, in Srinagar, Abdullah claimed the BJP was using money

power to poach his MLAs.

When asked, BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra categorically rejected Abdullah's charge as "speculative and without any basis", saying the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) does not believe in any action that deals a blow to democracy or runs counter to the democratic spirit.

"I find it astonishing when any leader speaks about his own party members in such a way, claiming that his people can be bought for sums like ₹30 crore or ₹12 crore," the BJP MP said.

"It reminds me of the time when Sushma (Swaraj) asked in Parliament: Are your MPs up for sale? Are your MLAs up for sale? Do you not even have enough faith in your own leaders to trust that they won't sell themselves?" Patra said, adding, "I feel that if this is the case, there ought to be some introspection as to what kind of people are in the party who can be bought."



Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah

On Saturday, BJP Rajya Sabha MP and national spokesperson Sudhansu Trivedi slammed Abdullah, describing his charge as "extremely irresponsible and baseless".

Trivedi also demanded that the J&K chief minister either provide "evidence" to substantiate his allegation or apologise.

J&K BJP spokesperson and MLA RS Pathania said if Abdullah does not apologise, the BJP will "file a defamation case against him for making misleading and unsubstantiated allegations intended to create confu-

sion among the people".

Trivedi further claimed Abdullah made such a "baseless" allegation just to deflect public attention from his Government's "incompetence, inaction and misgovernance" in J&K.

Speaking in the same vein, Pathania said, "Chief Minister Omar Abdullah should disclose the names of the MLAs who were allegedly offered money, identify the BJP leaders involved, and reveal when and where the alleged offers were made.

"If such a serious incident occurred, why was it not reported to the investigating agencies? An elected chief minister cannot make such allegations without placing evidence before the authorities," he added.

Pathania said the National Conference received a five-year mandate but was "exposed" within the first year itself for "failing" to honour its promises.

Betrayal of faith perpetrated under PM's patronage, alleges Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Sunday questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "silence" on the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and said the country will never forgive the BJP-RSS for the "betrayal of faith".

Congress general secretary in charge of communications, Jairam Ramesh, reiterated the party's demands for an independent investigation supervised by the Supreme Court, a forensic audit, a fixation of accountability and strict action against the guilty.

In a post in Hindi on X, Ramesh said, "Donation Theft: A Betrayal of Faith. A month has passed since the theft of donations at the Lord Shri Ram Temple came



Jairam Ramesh

to light, yet Prime Minister Modi, who is quick to claim credit for everything, remains silent when it comes to accountability." New facts emerging daily are exposing those who have politicised the Ram Temple issue, he said.

Even the Special Investigation Team (SIT), constituted ostensibly to resolve the matter, has been forced to acknowledge the daily disappearance of lakhs of rupees in offerings, Ramesh said. "The theft of donations at the Lord Shri Ram Temple cannot be

limited to just a few employees; yet, this Government — hostile to the cause of Ram — is intent on shielding the real culprits," he alleged.

The Congress has consistently maintained that the SIT, the FIR, and the resignations are merely attempts to hoodwink the nation, Ramesh said.

Government efforts to suppress the matter make it evident that Champat Rai and other temple trustees harbour deep secrets; this is why the Modi Government is taking no action against them, and their influence remains intact, Ramesh said.

"The Congress demands the following: An independent and impartial investigation supervised by the Supreme Court; a forensic audit; fixation of accountability; strict action against the guilty," he said.

Central Vista to be renamed Kartavya Bhawan area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal on Sunday said the Central Vista redevelopment area should be referred to as the “Kartavya Bhawan Complex” or “Kartavya Bhawan Area”, and that the name “Central Vista” should no longer be used.

Speaking at the foundation day of the Central Public Works Department, the minister said the new nomenclature should be reflected in all official documents and references.

“Until now, we have been repeatedly referring to it as ‘Central Vista’. From now on, please call it the ‘Kartavya

Bhawan Complex’ or ‘Kartavya Bhawan Area’. The name Central Vista has now been changed. Going forward, it should not be referred to by that name,” the minister said.

The Union minister said the entire precinct — comprising multiple Kartavya Bhawans, Kartavya Marg and any future Government buildings in the zone — would be known as the Kartavya Bhawan Area.

The Government plans to construct 10 buildings under the “Common Central Secretariat” to house ministries as part of the Central Vista redevelopment plan, out of which three have already been built. The minister said the newly con-



structed buildings have become part of the country's history, much like the century-old structures in the

national Capital that are remembered today along with those who built them. “A nation's Capital is not

built repeatedly in quick succession. Just as we remember those who built the iconic buildings a 100 years

ago, generations will remember those who built these Kartavya Bhawans. That is our good fortune,” he said.

In 2022, Prime Minister Narendra Modi officially renamed Rajpath — the two-kilometre stretch from Rashtrapati Bhavan to India Gate — as Kartavya Path.

The road was renamed to remove symbols of the colonial past and emphasise the importance of citizens' duties. Later, the newly built Government office buildings along this stretch were named “Kartavya Bhawans”.

Similarly, the new complex housing the Prime Minister's Office, Cabinet Secretariat and the office of the National Security Advisor was named “Seva Teerth”.

Day 23 of CJP protest: Sonam Wangchuk's health worsens

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Educator and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk's health declined further on Sunday, on the 15th day of his hunger strike, with doctors reporting a drop in his blood pressure and a total weight loss of 7.8 kg since the fast began.

The Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar in Delhi over alleged examination irregularities entered its 23rd day on Sunday, with Samajwadi Party MP Pushpendra Saroj and former Kerala health minister K K in attendance.

Shailaja, and former Kerala ministers KN Balagopal and P

Rajeev, also extended support to the agitation. According to a health update shared by the outfit, Wangchuk's blood pressure was recorded at 104/66 mm Hg, and total weight loss at 7.8 kg.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke shared the health update on X. “Day 15 of Sonam Wangchuk's hunger strike. When will the government wake up????” he wrote.

Addressing the gathering, Shailaja said, “We are all here to express our solidarity with the protest conducted by the CJP. It is on an important issue. We want accountability in examinations. We want a fair entrance examination system in our country.”

Omar targets Union Govt over delayed J&K Statehood

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Sunday once again ridiculed the Centre for repeatedly delaying the restoration of full Statehood to the Union Territory, even as he declared that the National Conference would now shift gears to a far more aggressive political campaign.

Omar, who arrived here in Jammu, was accorded a red carpet welcome inside the Maharaja Hari Singh Park, located on the banks of the river Tawi.

The choice of the venue, decorated with flags of the Jammu and Kashmir National Conference, raised many eyebrows.

In 2012, when the first statue of Maharaja Hari Singh was unveiled in Jammu, Omar Abdullah and members of his council of ministers had skipped the event. Later, PDP Chief and former Chief Minister Mehbooba Mufti inaugurated the Maharaja Hari Singh Park along with BJP's deputy CM Prof Nirmal Singh on March 17, 2018.

Omar attended the public rally in Maharaja Hari Singh Park ahead of July 13, which was observed as Martyrs' Day in the Kashmir valley before the Abrogation of Article 370.

For the first time, the two-State holidays on July 13 and December 5 were deleted from the list of public holidays by the LG administration on December 28, 2019, after the Abrogation of Articles 2019 and 35-A. So far, the Omar Abdullah-led Government has failed to fulfil its poll promise of restoring public holidays.



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah during the Delhi Chalo – We Want Our Statehood rally at Maharaja Hari Singh Park in Jammu on Sunday

On Sunday, when Omar announced a fresh round of protests beginning July 20 in New Delhi, it was a deliberate attempt to convey to the Centre that people across both the regions in the Union Territory were seeking early restoration of Statehood.

Addressing a public rally centred on the war cry “Delhi Chalo”, Abdullah said his party waited for two years after the Assembly election in the hope that the Centre would restore statehood.

“We have given the Central Government enough time. For nearly two years, we pursued talks for the restoration of Statehood. Now we will adopt a new strategy,” Abdullah said.

“The BJP leaders are making statements against NC's Jantar Mantar protest and saying that we will not get the statehood by doing this protest...If not in Delhi, then where?” he asked.

“If decisions concerning a

part of our own country cannot be taken in our own national Capital, where are they supposed to be taken?” he added.

Abdullah said the BJP constantly undermined its efforts for Statehood through protests in J&K, in the Assembly, and is now doing the same with its protest in the national Capital.

“So what do they expect us to do? Should we go to America and protest outside the White House to seek Jammu and Kashmir's Statehood? We are only asking for a promise made in our own country to be honoured in our own country's capital,” he said.

The National Conference leader accused the BJP of using Statehood as a bait to wield as a political instrument rather than fulfilling a constitutional commitment.

“If it is Modi's promise made on the soil of Katra, then it should be honoured,”

he said, referring to the prime minister's promise to restore Statehood.

Abdullah also referred to the Supreme Court calling for Statehood restoration “as soon as possible” after the completion of the electoral process.

“Those are not my words; they are the words of the Supreme Court,” he said.

He alleged that the Centre was punishing the people of Jammu and Kashmir by withholding statehood.

“The people of Jammu stood with the nation whenever the country faced challenges. Border districts bore the brunt of shelling, and Jammu opened its doors to those displaced by militancy. What crime have the people committed that they continue to be denied statehood?” Abdullah said.

Invoking Mahatma Gandhi, Abdullah said that during the post-Partition violence, the father of the nation had termed Jammu and Kashmir a symbol of communal harmony.

He also wondered whether the region was now being penalised for upholding the ideals of Hindu-Muslim-Sikh unity.

Abdullah said the National Conference will continue its campaign through democratic and peaceful means until Jammu and Kashmir regains full Statehood.

“We will continue knocking on the doors of our own nation's Capital. We will continue reminding the country's leadership of the promises made to the people of Jammu and Kashmir. We only ask that those promises be honoured,” he said.

Badrinath temple donation theft row: CCTV shows money, gold trail

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Dehradun

A suspended employee of the Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee is accused of stealing offerings from one of Hinduism's holiest shrines. According to police, CCTV footage shows him entering the donation counting room several times and hiding bundles of cash, gold and silver coins, sacred shaligram stones, and sealed envelopes containing offerings.

These allegations have caused a stir in Uttarakhand, especially since they follow a recent donation theft scandal at Ayodhya's Ram Mandir. The case has led to multiple investigations, an FIR, political debates, and new calls for transparency in temple finances. On July 2, routine counting of cash offerings at Badrinath Dham and silver coins, shaligram stones, and sealed envelopes with offerings estimated at ₹10,000 to ₹12,000 each.

Investigators believe the items were hidden in his office. They are also reviewing footage from June 25 and 29 to look for similar actions as the investigation



moves quickly. The Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee acted soon after the allegations appeared on social media. Nautiyal was placed under suspension after an initial internal inquiry found clear evidence of irregularities.

Accordingly, an FIR was filed at Badrinath police station against him under Sections 306 (theft by a servant of an employer's property) and 316(5) (criminal breach of trust) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), on the complaint of the temple's in-charge officer. Nautiyal has challenged his suspension and the FIR in the Uttarakhand High Court. The case is scheduled for July 16.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by the Uttarakhand Government is now handling the case. They have recorded statements from five key witnesses, reviewed CCTV footage, and checked the accused's call records and his movements.

The temple committee has provided three years of bank records to the SIT. Meanwhile, the Uttarakhand Government has set up a three-member high-level panel, led by Garhwal Commissioner Anand Swaroop, to review the situation and give recommendations within 15 days.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami has promised strict action against anyone found guilty. The Opposition Congress is leading the charge, with State President Ganesh Godiyal holding protests and accusing the BJP Government of failing to protect the sanctity of major pilgrimage sites in Uttarakhand. Senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh has called for more transparency in how temple donations are managed.

This controversy has sparked a national debate about how large sums of cash and other offerings at major temples are collected, counted, and kept safe,

especially after the Ayodhya case, in which an SIT recovered nearly ₹80 lakh and made several arrests.

Badrinath Dham attracts hundreds of thousands of pilgrims each year. The offerings here are more than just donations; they are acts of deep faith. When cash, gold, and sacred shaligram stones reportedly go missing from the counting room, it deeply erodes devotees' trust. This case has already led other temples in Uttarakhand to review their own procedures and take additional measures.

As several agencies investigate and the Uttarakhand High Court prepares to hear the accused's petition, one big question remains: How could such problems occur in a high-security religious institution, and what new safeguards will be introduced? The answers could change how India's major temples manage the large amounts of money and sacred offerings by devotees.

Operation Gangstran Te Vaar: Punjab Police's targets organised crime



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chadigarh

On 20 January 2026, the Punjab Police began Operation *Gangstran Te Vaar* after thorough planning. Instead of being a short-term, publicity-focused crackdown, this campaign was a long-term, intelligence-based effort that aimed at all parts of organised crime, including shooters, financiers, harbourers, passport fixers, foreign handlers, and prison networks.

The operation aimed to break up criminal groups rather than make headlines. Goals included verifying associates of absconders across the State, gathering intelligence from jails, taking action against travel agents who issue fake passports, and working with central agencies to put pressure on foreign-based operators through RCN and BCN mechanisms. From 20 January to 5 July 2026, the scale of the problem and the police response became clear.

Over 166 days, police conducted 87,039 raids, averaging more than 524 per day. They arrested 44,666 people connected to gangs, including 43,925 who were already wanted

for serious crimes. Police also caught 1,230 proclaimed offenders. Preventive detention orders were given to 18,871 people, while 18,192 others were checked and released after review. Altogether, the operation involved 81,729 people, including 78,956 wanted individuals or their close associates.

These numbers show a clear strategy. By handling arrests, preventive detentions, and verification drives separately, the Punjab Police focused on mapping criminal networks rather than simply filling jails. Checking 16,705 wanted people and 1,487 associates or relatives suggests the police are trying to close loopholes that let gangsters use others to hide their activities.

The focus on gathering intelligence from inside jails and conducting follow-up interviews shows that many gang leaders still run their operations from prison.

Breaking these command channels is as important as making arrests on the street. The items seized highlight the seriousness of the problem. Police found 828 firearms, 14 hand grenades, 2.5 kg of explosives, and 57 drones, which

shows that border smuggling now uses more advanced methods.

The drug haul was substantial. Beyond weapons and prison networks, the operation also targeted the money behind organised crime. Police seized large amounts of drugs: 635.62 kg of heroin, 400.88 kg of opium, 5,485.83 kg of poppy husk, over 22 million tablets, and significant amounts of *ganja* and ice.

Police also confiscated more than ₹3.18 crore in cash and drug money, along with gold and large amounts of illegal liquor. These seizures help cut off the flow of funds. A key part of the operation is its structure. By holding regular meetings and joint actions with neighbouring states and central agencies, the Punjab Police has moved beyond traditional boundaries. This broader approach helps the police focus on foreign handlers, check immigration histories, and coordinate Look-Out Circulars and Red Corner Notices. It shows that many Punjab-based gangs now receive their orders and money from outside India.

Taking action against travel agents who arrange fake passports closes a loophole that once allowed



key members to escape as police pressure increased. The large number of verifications and releases shows that police are being selective in their approach.

“Punjab Police's Gangstran Te Vaar campaign is showing strong results. We are working step by step to find and break up gang networks that put our youth and society at risk. This effort goes beyond law enforcement. It is a shared mission to take back our communities, protect families, and create a safer, brighter future for the next generation,” said DGP Punjab, Gaurav Yadav.

Real progress will depend on using intelligence to secure convictions that disrupt gang leadership. Arresting 741 associates and relatives, along with key gang members, shows an effort to weaken support networks. The bigger challenge will be to keep up pressure on gang funding and recruitment. Overall, “Operation *Gangstran Te Vaar* has shown that the Punjab Police have both the ability and the strategy to run a large-scale campaign against organised crime. The first six months have shown strong action; now the real challenge is to build on these gains.

LG Saxena approves reorganisation of tehsils, revenue villages in Ladakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Leh

In a landmark administrative reform, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena approved a comprehensive reorganisation and rationalisation of tehsils and revenue villages, following the creation of five new districts in the Union Territory, an official spokesman said on Sunday.

Under this reorganisation, 17 new tehsils have been created in Ladakh, taking the total number of tehsils to 32, from the existing 15, the spokesman said. He added that the move aims to opera-



tionalise the new districts while bringing public services to the people's doorsteps, thereby strengthening governance at the grassroots.

He said the new tehsils have been created on the recommendations of a UT-Level Committee constituted by

Saxena, following the notification of the new districts on April 27 this year.

The committee observed serious lacunae in the existing administrative units, including tehsils and revenue Villages, as they were not clearly demarcated. It found that boundaries of several tehsils extended across more than one district, resulting in administrative overlap and operational challenges.

Saxena also directed the chief secretary to immediately appoint tehsildars, with one officer assigned to the independent charge of a tehsil.

Invitation For Bids (IFB)

The Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Assam Skill University Project (ASUP) cum Registrar, Assam Skill University (ASU) (“the Purchaser”) invites online bids from eligible bidders for the below mentioned Packages at Assam Skill University:

#	Package No.	Package Name	Date of Publication	Deadline for Submission	
			Date	Time	Time
1	GS02/ASU/CE/013	Equipment for Drone Lab	13 July 2026	13 August 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
2	GS02/ASU/TEC/063	Equipment for Artificial Intelligence & Machine Learning (Basic and Advanced)	13 July 2026	13 August 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
3	GS02/ASU/AFT/018	Equipment for Dairy, Fish, Meat, Poultry, and Cereal-Pulse-Oil seed Processing Labs	13 July 2026	13 August 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
4	GS02/ASU/AFT/078	Equipment for Advanced Food Technology (Food & Vegetable Processing, Packed House) and Sensory Analytics Lab	13 July 2026	13 August 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)

Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal <https://assamtenders.gov.in/>.

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Editor's
TAKE

Vietnam boat capsize: A preventable tragedy

Fifteen families are now mourning the death of their loved ones. The only honest tribute to them would be to ensure that this will not happen again

Fifteen Indian tourists – colleagues on what was meant to be a light-hearted company outing – drowned on Saturday when their speedboat capsized barely 400 metres off Vietnam's Phu Quoc island. Of the 36 people aboard, 21 survived, pulled out by jet skis and nearby fishermen even as others remained trapped inside the overturned hull. The sea took them so close to shore that this reads less like an act of nature and more like a systems failure – the kind that, with basic precautions, does not have to end in a body count.

Survivor accounts describe a familiar sequence of small failures compounding into catastrophe. The boat left Hon May Rut Ngoai island into deteriorating weather, and eyewitnesses say it tipped over within minutes, well before it should have been anywhere near open water in such conditions. More troubling still, widely circulated – though not independently verified – video appears to show passengers clutching life jackets instead of wearing them, this despite survivors telling authorities that the crew had instructed everyone to put them on before departure.

A jacket held in the hand saves no one once the water closes over a boat. Investigators are also examining whether the vessel was carrying more passengers than it was certified for, and whether it should have been cleared to sail into worsening seas at all. What makes this hardest to accept as simple misfortune is that Vietnam buried 39 people, most of them its own citizens, in an almost identical disaster barely a year ago, when the tourist boat Wonder Sea capsized in a Ha Long Bay thunderstorm. A country that has already lived through its deadliest sea accident in years cannot plausibly be surprised the next time a boat overturns in rough weather with unworn life jackets aboard. That repetition is the real criminal negligence, and it should shape the response. Vietnamese authorities need enforcement, not exhortation: verified life-jacket checks before every departure, weather-linked suspensions of sailing that individual operators cannot override to protect bookings, and passenger counts checked against certified capacity rather than taken on trust. Prime Minister Le Minh Hung has ordered an investigation; it must end in a public report with real consequences – licence suspensions and prosecutions where warranted – not a quiet settlement followed by business as usual once the next tourist season begins.

India, in turn, cannot treat this as someone else's regulatory failure. With outbound leisure and corporate travel to Southeast Asia rising fast, the Ministry of External Affairs should move beyond generic country advisories toward route- and operator-specific safety warnings, and press Vietnam bilaterally for verifiable safety certification of tourist-boat operators. Companies organising offsites abroad should vet transport safety with the same rigour they apply to hotels and venues.

Fifteen families are now arranging funerals instead of welcoming colleagues home from a work trip. The only honest tribute left to give them is a system that will not let such thing happen again

The missing grammar of land governance

India's land reforms have entered a decisive phase where digitisation alone cannot resolve long-standing disputes over ownership, boundaries and possession. The real challenge lies in reconciling fragmented records, maps and ground realities through a common institutional framework that makes every land transaction transparent, accurate and legally reliable



VIVEK
KUMAR
SINGH

India's land problem is not a shortage of laws, records or institutions. It is the absence of a shared grammar. The cadastral map, record of rights, mutation entry, registered deed, court order and actual possession often describe the same parcel differently. Citizens encounter these contradictions as delay, fraud or litigation. Administrators encounter them as files that refuse to match the field. The next stage of land reform by making the components of the land system intelligible to one another. The questions are no longer only who owns the land, but where the parcel lies, what supports the claim, who possesses it, whether each change is reflected in both record and map, and which institution must act when the answers diverge. India's land governance has passed through four broad phases. In the pre-colonial phase, land was tied to cultivation, sovereignty, custom and community. The colonial State made it administratively visible through surveys, settlements, cadastral maps, records of rights, registration, revenue courts, the Collector and acquisition law, principally for revenue and control. Post-Independence policy shifted towards abolition of intermediaries, tenancy reform, ceilings, consolidation, Bhoodan, tribal land protection, homestead security, settlement of public land and acquisition for planned development. The fourth phase is digitisation and integration, which aspires to connect textual records, maps, transactions, municipal databases, court orders and physical possession.

These phases have accumulated rather than replaced one another. Colonial records coexist with unfinished reform mandates and new digital platforms. The contemporary land agenda therefore extends beyond title and mutation to delayed acquisition and compensation, displacement and rehabilitation, landlessness and settlement, fragmented holdings and incomplete consolidation, tenancy and customary rights, public land and commons, and urban expansion that often outruns both maps and law.

The fourth phase must not be mistaken for computerisation. Its purpose is not to place old records on new screens, but to make the State's memory of land reliable and current. An inaccurate paper entry remains inaccurate after scanning. Without cleansing, legal validation, audit trails, interoperability and continuous updating, digitisation merely gives inherited errors new authority.

This is why land problems are better understood as Land Ailments than as one undifferentiated category of disputes. A defective survey, unrecorded inheritance, fraudulent transfer,



boundary mismatch, delayed compensation, insecure settlement, fragmented holding and encroachment on a common arise from different institutional failures. They require diagnosis before remedy. Triage must then determine urgency, conflict potential and the proper administrative, judicial or law-and-order response. A routine succession entry, a contested acquisition award and a communally sensitive encroachment cannot be processed through the same lens.

The most useful field test is the Record-Map-Possession Triangle. Every serious matter should be examined through three questions: What does the record say? What does the map show? Who is in possession? When the three broadly agree, the claim is relatively stable. When they diverge, caution is essential. A record without possession may be contested or obsolete. Possession without record may be illegal, informal, customary or simply unregularised. A map without ground verification may not reflect subdivision, erosion, accretion, consolidation or urban change. The triangle is the diagnostic tool. Record-Map-Possession Convergence is the administrative objective. It means reconciling the three through lawful verification and continuous updating until the record identifies the right, the map locates the parcel and possession is either validated or addressed through due process. Digitisation can make this convergence dynamic only if it moves beyond textual updating. Where States have created de novo digital maps through aerial photography, high-resolution satellite imagery or comparable geospatial methods, the next leap should be spatial mutation alongside textual mutation. A verified change arising from transfer, succession, partition, acquisition, subdivision or consolidation should, wherever legally and technically feasible, produce a corresponding spatial update. This can bridge the historic gap between what the regis-

ter records and what the map locates on the ground. It is a transition the modern State cannot afford to miss.

Artificial intelligence can assist, but only as an auditable decision-support tool. In consolidation, it can compare parcel configurations using contiguity, access, irrigation, value and possession. In acquisition, geospatial analysis can test alternative alignments and flag avoidable impacts on habitations, commons and productive land before a route hardens into a project decision. In compensation, it can identify anomalies, omitted interests and likely liabilities. But AI cannot cure defective maps, outdated valuations or incomplete records.

The same clarity is needed in the debate on title. The familiar contest between "conclusive" and "presumptive" title often freezes reform in abstraction. A more usable distinction is between foundational and current title. Survey and settlement provide the foundation through the original mapping and recording of parcels and rights. Mutation-backed records provide the current administrative frame by reflecting later transfers, succession, partition, acquisition, consolidation and court orders.

Mutation should neither be romanticised as final ownership nor dismissed as a meaningless fiscal entry. Civil courts remain necessary for complex title adjudication. Yet where mutation follows notice, objection, reasoned orders, appeal, revision and a digital audit trail, it represents the State's best administrative recognition of the current lawful claim, subject to judicial correction. Treating it as irrelevant weakens land markets, citizen services and the credibility of public action.

Acquisition shows why this grammar must extend beyond title. A project may have a valid notification and still falter because the alignment was poorly chosen, ownership data were outdated,

valuation lacked transparency, compensation was delayed or possession was taken without completing rehabilitation and record correction. Acquisition should be managed as one chain from geospatial planning and social-impact assessment to award, payment, possession, rehabilitation and post-acquisition textual and spatial mutation. Compensation is the bridge between public purpose and procedural legitimacy.

At the other end lies landlessness. Settlement of homestead or cultivable land cannot end with a paper entitlement. The parcel must be identified, measured, made accessible, delivered in possession, entered in the record and protected against later dispossession. A settlement without secure possession and corresponding records is welfare announced but not delivered. Consolidation, too, deserves recovery from the margins of policy. Modern cadastral technology, transparent valuation, participatory planning, AI-assisted alternatives and simultaneous textual and spatial updating can give consolidation new life as both an agricultural and spatial-planning reform. Citizens suffer because government is organised in silos while land problems are not. A No-Wrong-Door approach need not empower every office to decide every dispute. It should require the first receiving office to record the grievance, identify the ailment, route it to the competent forum and track whether a response follows.

Government land may be recorded in one register, used by another department, encroached in patches, omitted from a spatial layer and rediscovered only when a project needs it. Live inventories, GIS linkage, departmental reconciliation and field verification are essential. The State must know its own land before it can protect, settle or deploy it.

The test of reform is not how many records have moved online, but whether the record identifies the right, the map locates the parcel and lawful possession is secured - or corrected through due process. India has begun building the digital infrastructure for that convergence. It must now make spatial mutation, reliable current records and coordinated remedies part of the ordinary machinery of the State, so that rights, reality and public purpose do not drift apart again.

The writer is an ex-IAS officer and is presently Chairman, RERA Bihar. He served as Principal Secretary, Department of Revenue and Land Reforms, Bihar

PIC TALK



Macaques at the Galta Ji Temple, popularly known as the 'Monkey Temple', in Jaipur, Rajasthan

PHOTO: PTI



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

We spend close to a third of our lives asleep, and treat almost none of it as time well spent. It's a fact that sleep is the best form of relaxation, close to meditation; that's why those who sleep well always stay well and feel well. It's a fact that if we get sound sleep during the night, we wake up refreshed, more active, and feeling more energetic. However, in today's world, getting sound sleep has become a rare occasion because millions of people suffer from sleep disorders like sleep apnea, insomnia, restless leg syndrome, and narcolepsy. In addition, the number of those who get a very broken, fitful sleep is many times higher. Sadly, many of these individuals resort to sleeping pills and drugs, which ultimately make the problem worse. This is because we do not consider these as serious issues and avoid the fact that these sleep disorders interfere with

The healing power of sleep

our body's ability to recuperate the energy needed for the next day. We usually make a huge mistake by viewing sleep merely as a time of inactivity for the body. Whereas, in reality, during the hours of sleep, when we appear to be most passive, something within us is intensely active, recharging the body cells for the next day.

Sleep is considered to be the greatest remedy to overcome tiredness. It is so critical that it simply overtakes one when it's needed by the body; hence, it can be put off for some time but cannot be shunned. Healthful, soothing slumber that reactivates the muscles, nerves, and brain cells is one of nature's greatest rejuvenators. Therefore, it is absolutely essential to life, just like air, water, and food. During sleep, the body is busy in activities like tissue repair, healing, restocking of organs and cells with fuel, and replacing old cells with new ones. These processes occur at a much higher rate while we are asleep compared to when we are awake. The biggest hindrance contributing to sleeplessness is poor mental health. Our habits of negative thinking and unrighteous actions during the day cause sleep disturbances during the night. Repeated suppression of the voice of one's conscience impairs mental health, which results in negative personality traits and insomnia. Another important factor that affects our sleep is the food we eat. It's a medically proven fact that poor mental health adversely affects one's eating habits, which, in turn, drastically influences our sleep and health. For instance, those who have several cups of tea, coffee, and colas intake lots of caffeine, which contributes to their inability to sleep.

Under such a medical condition, proper meditation techniques can be of great help if practiced regularly.

There have been a lot of deliberations and debates over the hours of sleep one should have. After all, how much sleep does one need? Well! Doctors say that different conditions require different lengths of sleep. Under the best of conditions in terms of sleep, fresh air, water, food, physical work or exercise, and positive influences, one would stay asleep as long as one's system needs.

Some people, like the yogis, who are always in a state of meditation, feel fine with even four to five hours or less, whereas others might need more. Also, our age, general physical health, work routine, environment, and habitat play key roles in determining the hours of sleep we need. Remember!! Our consciousness will automatically return when the purpose of sleep is fulfilled. Hence, there is really no such thing as oversleeping. However, there is certainly such a phenomenon as undersleeping, because, for some reason or another, our sleep gets sacrificed in pursuing other pleasures of life. The old adage, "Early to bed, early to rise, makes a man healthy, wealthy, and wise," seems to fall on deaf ears in our times. Hence, if we jeopardise our sleep for silly reasons, we are knowingly undermining our health. So, it's better to be wise for our own health benefit and make it a habit to disengage the mind from thoughts daily before going to bed to give it sleep-inducing relaxation.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

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A NEW CHAPTER IN INDIA-NEW ZEALAND RELATIONS

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to New Zealand marks a historic milestone, being the first by an Indian Prime Minister in four decades since Rajiv Gandhi's visit in 1986.

The decision by both countries to elevate their ties to a Strategic Partnership reflects India's expanding diplomatic outreach across the Indo-Pacific.

The signing of a defence cooperation arrangement and greater collaboration on maritime security demonstrate their shared commitment to ensuring peace and stability in the region.

Equally significant is the renewed emphasis on concluding the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement, which has the potential to boost bilateral trade, strengthen MSMEs and integrate them into global supply chains. Cooperation in agriculture, dairy,

education and technology can further deepen economic engagement.

The ambitious target of doubling bilateral trade by 2030 reflects the confidence both nations have in the partnership.

Their commitment to working together in multilateral forums also reinforces shared democratic values and common global interests. This visit has laid a strong foundation for a dynamic and mutually beneficial relationship that promises long-term strategic and economic gains. The visit signals a new era in India-New Zealand relations, strengthening strategic trust, expanding economic opportunities and reaffirming both nations' commitment to a stable, prosperous and rules-based Indo-Pacific region.

P VICTOR SELVARAJ, TIRUNELVELI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Strengthen tourist safety abroad

The tragic capsizing of a speedboat carrying Indian tourists near Vietnam's Phu Quoc Island, in which at least 15 lives were lost, is deeply distressing. While search and rescue operations continue and the Indian Embassy closely monitors the situation, the tragedy also serves as a stark reminder of the need for stricter safety standards in tourist destinations. Many popular island excursions rely on small boats and speedboats that may be vulnerable to sudden weather changes. Authorities in host countries must ensure that operators strictly comply with safety regulations, including passenger limits, availability of life jackets and emergency preparedness.

At the same time, Indian tourists travelling abroad should remain cautious and verify the safety credentials of tour operators before undertaking such excursions. The Ministry of External Affairs should continue extending all possible assistance to the affected families and coordinate closely with Vietnamese authorities. As international travel becomes increasingly popular among Indians, greater awareness about travel safety and stronger enforcement of maritime regulations are essential. One hopes the rescue efforts conclude swiftly and the bereaved families receive timely support.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Affordable medicine for all

The Centre's decision to bring 39 additional drug formulations under price control through the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority is a commendable step towards making healthcare more affordable. Medicines used for hypertension, diabetes, heart ailments, epilepsy, HIV, bacterial infections and certain cancers are essential for millions of patients who require lifelong treatment. Lower prices will significantly reduce their financial burden. This initiative complements the remarkable success of the Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana, which has enabled millions to access quality generic medicines at affordable rates. However, the network of Janaushadhi Kendras must expand much faster so that even remote villages and small towns have easy access to these medicines. Equally important is addressing the excessive mark-ups charged by many conventional chemists, where identical medicines often cost several times more than their generic counterparts. The government should encourage more pharmacies to function as Janaushadhi outlets or adopt similar pricing practices. Affordable medicines are as vital as quality education in building a healthier and more equitable society. Such initiatives not only reduce household healthcare expenses but also strengthen public confidence in India's healthcare system.

R.S. NARULA | PATIALA

Bold move against abandoned vehicles

Abandoned vehicles have become a common eyesore in many Indian cities, occupying valuable public space and creating unnecessary inconvenience for pedestrians and motorists alike. Left unattended for months or even years, such vehicles obstruct traffic, reduce parking availability and pose safety hazards. Karnataka's initiative to identify, clamp and eventually auction abandoned vehicles in Bengaluru is therefore a welcome and practical step.

Issuing notices to owners and providing them an opportunity to reclaim their vehicles after paying a fine ensures fairness, while towing and auctioning unclaimed vehicles within a stipulated period will help reclaim public spaces. The identification of more than 1,500 such vehicles highlights the scale of the problem. Other metropolitan cities should consider adopting similar measures to improve urban mobility and civic discipline. At the same time, authorities should also act against vehicles illegally parked on footpaths and other public spaces, even if only temporarily, as they inconvenience pedestrians, particularly senior citizens and persons with disabilities. Karnataka deserves appreciation for addressing a long-neglected civic issue through a firm yet balanced approach.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

A rising Bengal for a stronger Bharat

A confident Bengal, firmly anchored in its civilisational heritage and fully aligned with the aspirations of a rising India, would indeed be the finest tribute to the vision of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee and to countless patriots, whose sacrifices and lifelong dedication helped preserve the idea of an indivisible Bharat



SHUKENDU SEKHAR RAY

History often comes full circle. For generations, many believed that West Bengal, once the intellectual, cultural and nationalist nerve centre of India, had gradually drifted away from the ideals that shaped modern Bharat. Today, with the emergence of the state's first-ever BJP government in independent India, Bengal stands at the threshold of a historic

transformation. For millions of people, this is not merely a change in political leadership; it represents the grand revival of an idea rooted in nationalism, cultural pride and inclusive development.

A new resurgent Bengal has begun to emerge, one that seeks to reconnect with its glorious civilisational heritage while embracing the aspirations of a modern India. The fresh wave of nationalism rising from the eastern frontier of the country is strengthening the spirit of national unity from East to West, reaffirming that India's unity in diversity is best preserved through a shared commitment to nationhood. For me, this transformation carries a profound personal significance. My hero and dearest father, late Shibendu Sekhar Ray, dedicated his life to the ideals of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee, the visionary founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh. He regarded Dr Mookerjee not merely as a political leader but as a statesman who combined intellectual brilliance with extraordinary courage and selfless public service. His unwavering commitment to national integration profoundly shaped my father's life, which in turn influenced my own understanding of public service and patriotism. Long before the trauma of Partition, Bengal had already endured one of the greatest human tragedies in modern history, the catastrophic Great Bengal Famine of 1943. Millions of hapless, innocent Bengalis perished from starvation and disease. During this period of immense suffering, Dr Mookerjee emerged as one of Bengal's foremost humanitarian leaders. He organised hundreds of relief camps across undivided Bengal to provide food, shelter and medical assistance to famine-ravaged families. Dr. Mookerjee's relief initiatives became a lifeline for countless distressed families and demonstrated his unwavering commitment to the welfare of the people. The horrors of the Partition of 1947 inflicted another deep wound upon Bengal. Families were uprooted overnight, communities were divided, and countless innocent people became victims of violence, persecution and displacement. Amidst this tragedy, Dr. Mookerjee emerged as one of the strongest voices advocating the protection of the people of West Bengal and safeguarding India's national strength. His relentless efforts before the Bengal Boundary Commission ensured that substantial portions of Bengal remained within the Indian Union, thereby preserving not only its territory but also the cultural and civilisational continuity of the nation. My father played a meaningful role in this historic chapter. At the instance of Dr. Mookerjee, he appeared before the Bengal Boundary Commission both as a Pleader and as a representative of the Hindu Mahasabha alongside the eminent barrister N. C. Chatterjee. Through persuasive legal arguments and careful presentation of demographic, historical and administrative facts, he successfully pleaded for the retention of Malda, then a Muslim-majority district, within the Indian Union. His contribution remains an important yet lesser-known chapter in the constitutional and legal struggle to protect India's territorial integrity during Partition.

It was therefore deeply moving when India's longest-serving Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi, during his public rally in Malda, acknowledged Dr Mookerjee's historic contribution and remembered my father for his role during the turbulent years surrounding Partition. Such recognition transcends a single individual or family. It honours thousands of forgotten patriots whose sacrifices strengthened the foundations of an independent and united India. For decades after Independence, many in Bengal believed that the state gradually drifted away from its nationalist foundations. Political priorities shifted, ideological battles intensified, and the cultural confidence that once defined Bengal appeared to diminish. The land that produced Raja Rammohan Roy, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, Swami Vivekananda, Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose and Hindu icon Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee increasingly became a theatre of ideological polarisation. Many citi-



BENGAL'S GREATEST STRENGTH HAS ALWAYS BEEN ITS TRADITION OF INTELLECTUAL OPENNESS, CULTURAL INCLUSIVENESS AND PEACEFUL COEXISTENCE. EVERY CITIZEN WHO RESPECTS THE CONSTITUTION OF INDIA AND CONTRIBUTES TO NATION-BUILDING DESERVES EQUAL OPPORTUNITY, DIGNITY AND JUSTICE

The writer is a prominent BJP leader from the state of West Bengal

zens have also expressed concerns regarding illegal immigration from Bangladesh, demographic changes in border districts, political violence and the weakening of institutions entrusted with preserving Bengal's rich cultural heritage. These concerns have remained central to public discourses for decades and continue to influence political debates throughout the state. Supporters of the present political transformation believe that a nationalist government presents an opportunity to address these longstanding challenges through constitutional governance, stronger border management, effective law enforcement, transparent administration and policies that uphold equal justice for every citizen irrespective of religion, caste or community. West Bengal's cultural legacy has always transcended narrow identities. It has produced poets, philosophers, scientists, freedom fighters, reformers and educationists whose contributions enriched not merely Bengal but the entire nation. Any meaningful effort to revive Bengal must therefore combine economic development with cultural renaissance, ensuring that future generations remain deeply connected to their civilisational roots while embracing innovation, entrepreneurship and global opportunities. The emergence of new leadership under my dynamic and fearless younger brother, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, has generated hope among many citizens who aspire for transparent governance, industrial revival, employment generation and social harmony. Having known him closely since our college days, I have witnessed his political evolution, his tireless organisational abilities and his unwavering commitment to public service. His leadership symbolises the aspirations of a new generation that believes Bengal can once again emerge as one of India's foremost states in industry, education, culture and governance. The road ahead, however, remains challenging. Restoring investor confidence, creating sustainable employment, modernising infrastructure, strengthening education and healthcare, improving law and order and rebuilding institutional trust will require sustained effort, efficient administration and active public participation. Political change alone cannot achieve these objectives unless accompanied by accountable governance and a shared commitment to development. Equally important is the need to heal social divisions. Bengal's greatest strength has always been its tradition of intellectual openness, cultural inclusiveness and peaceful coexistence. Every citizen who respects the Constitution of India and contributes to nation-building deserves equal opportunity, dignity and justice. The enduring philosophy of "live and let live" must continue to guide Bengal's future. As we look towards the future, Bengal has a historic opportunity to reclaim its rightful place as India's cultural, intellectual and economic beacon. The state's exceptional human capital, entrepreneurial spirit, literary tradition, strategic geography and rich heritage can once again make it a gateway for economic growth, regional cooperation and national resurgence. The generation that witnessed the famine, Partition and displacement must never be forgotten. Their suffering and sacrifice remind us that freedom carries responsibilities alongside rights. Preserving India's unity, strengthening democratic institutions, promoting constitutional values and protecting our shared civilisational heritage remain enduring national obligations. If this new chapter succeeds in restoring peace, attracting investment, reviving industry, celebrating Bengal's cultural richness, strengthening social harmony and reaffirming national unity, it will represent far more than a landslide electoral victory. It will mark the renaissance of a state whose contributions have shaped India's past and whose future can once again illuminate the nation's path to a Vikshit Bharat. A confident Bengal, firmly anchored in its civilisational heritage and fully aligned with the aspirations of a rising India, would indeed be the finest tribute to the vision of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee and to countless patriots, including my father, Shibendu Shekhar Ray whose sacrifices and lifelong dedication helped preserve the idea of an indivisible Bharat.

Reclaiming footpaths, losing livelihoods

BY DEEKSHA BAJPAI TEWARI, UPMA GAUTAM, AND NANDINI SINGH RANDHAWA

Every city tells a story through its footpaths. Some stories narrate the tale of accessibility and inclusion, while others are painful stories of survival. The Supreme Court's recognition of walkability as a fundamental right in the case of Maniyar Iliyaz @ Shaik Riyaz v. P. Ayyapa (2026), did more than just redefine urban mobility, it reaffirmed the constitutional promise of accessible and inclusive public spaces. This was a call to rethink how Indian cities are designed and governed. The Greater Bangalore Authority was amongst the first to answer that call by clearing 200 km of footpath of unauthorised structures, temporary vending space, kiosks and other encroachment. This exercise prompted protest by street vendors who questioned whether making cities walkable should come at the cost of their livelihood. Public reaction on social media reflected the same divide. While some praised the clearance as a necessary step towards restoring pedestrian access, while others said that street vendors are not to be treated as encroachers. Around the same time, Bombay High Court while hearing a matter concerning road widening and recurring waterlogging, remarked that Mumbai's flooding is "our own creation" and "can't blame BMC alone". This judicial observation invites an uncomfortable question that if the Municipal Corporation cannot alone be blamed, then who else should be held accountable? Urban spaces are shared by multiple stakeholders. Pedestrian seek safe and accessible streets, street vendors depend on them for their livelihood and municipal authorities are entrusted with their governance.

While Citizens and street vendors share the responsibility for respecting public space but it is the local urban body that bears the statutory obligation to regulate, plan and manage them and is failing miserably in doing so. Even Delhi is no different wherein the High Court of Delhi have time and again flagged the lackadaisical functioning of the municipal body. The same governance deficit is evident in Delhi. Delhi High Court has highlighted delays in approving vending plans and directed authorities to constitute TVCs and finalise certificate of vending. Courts continue to remind municipal authorities to perform duties that should have become routine administrative functions, exposing a deeper institutional failure in the governance of public spaces. India's Footpaths have thus become far more than just strips of concrete; they have become newest constitutional battlegrounds. On one side stands the pedestrian, armed with the Supreme Court's recognition of walkability as a fundamental right. On the other stands the street vendor, whose livelihood also enjoys constitutional protection. These developments reveal the increasingly contested nature of urban public space, where footpaths are not just physical infrastructure but facilitate pedestrian movement, sustain informal livelihoods and preserve essential urban infrastructure. While walkability is now affirmed as a fundamental right, the Supreme Court has also affirmed in Sodan Singh v. New Delhi Municipal Committee (1989), Bombay Hawkers' Union v. Bombay Municipal Corporation (1985) and Olga Tellis v. Bombay Municipal Corporation (1985) that street vendors possess a constitutionally protected right to carry trade under Article 19(1)(g) on streets. More recently, the apex court clarified that anti-encroachment drives cannot be undertaken in a mechanical manner, instead the authorities must provide for rehabilitation of street vendors in the vending zones and must minimise disruption of their livelihood in accordance with the Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014. These conundrums lead to the question of whether walkability and livelihood are mutually exclusive?

From Bangalore's ambitious footpath reclamation drive to Delhi's institutional implementation failure and Mumbai's prolonged courtroom battle, all three cities narrate the same story. The battle for the footpath has become the defining symbol of urban governance failure. Parliament enacted the Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014, to replace ad-hoc evictions with a structured framework based on surveys, participatory town vending committees, notified vending zones, certificates of vending and rehabilitation. Yet more than a decade after its enactment, delayed surveys, incomplete Town Vending Committees, pending Certificates of Vending and unnotified vending zones have left vendors in legal uncertainty, forcing civic authorities to repeatedly rely on anti-encroachment drives. Footpaths are reclaimed, vendors are evicted, protests erupt, petitions reach the courts, and yet the cycle begins all over again. Beneath this recurring cycles is the role of corruption in governance of public space. Rent seeking, selective enforcement and unofficial payments, exposes vendors to arbitrary decision making, local power brokers and other informal actors to exercise influence over access to vending spaces. Therefore the real congestion on Indian footpaths is institutional.

Across the world, smart city initiatives have often regarded street vendors as visual blight whose presence is perceived to undermine aesthetics, efficiency and marketability of modern cities. Smart cities discourse have framed street vendors as manifestation of urban disorder and visual clutter, justifying their removal from public spaces. This perception however overlooks the indispensable role that street vendors play within the urban informal economy by generating employment for millions, making essential good affordable, supporting local supply chains and keeping public space active and accessible. The paradox of contemporary urban planning, therefore, is that cities celebrate walkability but often pursue it at the cost of displacing the very workers who keep cities economically and socially active. Walkability and livelihood are therefore not mutually exclusive constitutional aspirations, they become adversaries only when cities govern street vending through administrative delays, regulatory ambiguity and eviction driven enforcement instead of planning. Despite their different context, Bangalore, Delhi and Mumbai tell the same story. The message is strikingly clear, persistent failure of urban local bodies to implement the Act which has transformed into recurring constitutional controversies. The constitution never required the cities to choose between right to walk and right to work, it is the governance failure that has failed to make them coexist. A truly walkable city is not one that merely clears its footpaths, it is the one that creates space for both movement and livelihood, proving that constitutional rights need not compete when institutions do their jobs. Until that vision is realised, every cleared pavement will continue to raise the same unsettling question: are we building smarter cities, or simply more exclusionary ones?



Dr. Deeksha Bajpai Tewari is Professor, Department of Geography, Dyal Singh College, Dr. Upma Gautam is Professor, University School of Law and Legal Studies, GGSIP University. Nandini Singh Randhawa is Ph.D. Scholar, School of Law and Legal Studies, GGSIP University.

Dalit political realignment in Uttar Pradesh: A decisive tilt towards the BJP



SANJAY KUMAR

Over the past decade, Uttar Pradesh's political landscape has undergone significant transformation, with one of the most notable shifts occurring in the voting preferences of Dalit communities. For years, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) was widely regarded as the primary political representative of Dalits in the state. In 2007, BSP secured a decisive majority and formed the government, not only offering Dalits political representation but also instilling a sense of confidence that they could play a decisive role in the corridors of power. However, nearly two decades later, that political equation has undergone a marked change.

The early signs of this realignment became evident during the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, when the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), under the leadership of Narendra Modi, achieved a historic victory by winning 71 seats in Uttar Pradesh. This was followed by another landmark moment in 2017, when Yogi Adityanath was sworn in as Chief Minister after the BJP secured a resounding majority in the state assembly. These developments signaled a deeper social and political reconfiguration within Uttar Pradesh's Dalit politics.

In the years that followed, the BJP, particularly under Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, succeeded in expanding its political acceptance among a significant section of the Dalit community-most notably among non-Jatav Dalit groups. This shift was not the result of a single slogan or short-term electoral campaign. Rather, it emerged from a sustained, multi-pronged strategy that combined effective law and order management, the delivery of welfare schemes, cultural recognition, and greater social representation.

The most visible manifestation of this change has been the steady erosion of the BSP's support base. The party that had polled nearly 30 percent of the vote and formed a majority government in 2007 has witnessed a consistent decline in its vote share over the subsequent decade and a half. Political analyses and post-poll surveys conducted by CSDS-Lokniti indicate that Dalit voters have not moved as a monolith. While the BSP has retained a relatively strong hold over its traditional Jatav support base for a longer period, it has lost considerable ground among non-Jatav Dalit communities such as the Pasis, Valmiki, Dhobis, Koris, and Khatiks, where the BJP has made notable inroads.

However, Dalit political behaviour cannot be understood through electoral data alone. In rural Uttar Pradesh, questions of security have long



been central to Dalit political consciousness. Land disputes, wage-related conflicts, social dominance, and local strong-arm tactics have historically shaped Dalit perceptions of the state's role. The Yogi Adityanath government has sought to project itself through a firm commitment to law and order and a policy of "zero tolerance" towards crime. By asserting that action would be taken irrespective of an offender's caste or political influence, the government has been able to foster a degree of confidence among sections of the Dalit community regarding the state's impartiality and their personal security. This sentiment draws added resonance from the collective memory of the 1995 Guest House Incident, in which then Chief Minister Mayawati was attacked. For many Dalits, the inci-

dent was perceived not merely as an act of political violence but as an assault on their collective dignity. Even after nearly three decades, the episode continues to surface in discussions around Dalit political identity and relations with other parties. The BJP has strategically invoked this memory in its political discourse to position itself as a defender of Dalit dignity and security. While improved law and order has strengthened perceptions of security, the direct delivery of welfare benefits has helped establish a tangible connection between the government and citizens. The Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM) Trinity and Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mechanisms have significantly improved the efficiency of welfare delivery. Schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Ujjwala Yojana, Ayushman Bharat, free ration distribution, and various scholarship programmes have reached a large number of Scheduled Caste households. The state government has further supplemented these efforts through initiatives focused on expanding scholarships for Scheduled Caste students, promoting self-employment among Dalit youth, developing Dalit-majority villages, and launching targeted programmes such as the Dr. Ambedkar Zero Poverty Mission. It is at this intersection that a new political category-the "beneficiary class"-has begun to emerge in Uttar Pradesh politics.

Increasingly, voting behaviour is being shaped not only by caste identity but also by the tangible benefits derived from government schemes.

Politics, however, is not driven solely by material benefits. Symbols and the politics of recognition carry equal weight. Recognising this, the BJP has actively integrated Dalit icons into the broader cultural and political narrative. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has frequently described Dr. B.R. Ambedkar as the chief architect of the Indian Constitution and a towering figure of social justice. The state government has also taken steps to protect Ambedkar statues, improve basic infrastructure in Dalit settlements, and accord greater public recognition to figures such as Maharishi Valmiki, Sant Ravidas, Maharaja Bijli Pasi, and Veerangana Uda Devi. Through these measures, the government has sought to convey that Dalit icons belong not to any single community but to the shared heritage of Indian society.

In essence, the Dalit voter in Uttar Pradesh today is no longer a passive recipient of political mobilisation. Instead, the community has evolved into a more discerning electorate-one that evaluates political options through the interconnected lenses of security, dignity, economic opportunity, social inclusion, and constitutional assurances. This marks a significant maturation in the state's Dalit politics.

The author is a post-doctoral fellow at Jawaharlal Nehru University



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Order Order

Delhi tribunal gives ₹30.45 lakh to victim’s family

A Delhi Motor Accident Claims Tribunal has awarded ₹30.45 lakh as compensation to the family of a newspaper distributor who died after being hit by a tractor while delivering newspapers in northeast Delhi in 2020.

Presiding Officer Manish Sharma was hearing a claim petition filed by a family member of Umesh Chand Shukla and directed Magma HDI General Insurance Company, the insurer of the offending vehicle, to pay ₹30.45 lakh along with interest at nine per cent per annum to the victim’s family.

In an order dated July 3, the court said, “This tribunal is constrained to hold respondent no.1 (tractor driver) guilty of gross neglect and default in driving the offending vehicle at the relevant time leading to the death of the deceased.”

According to the tribunal, Shukla, 42, was distributing newspapers on his bicycle on Wazirabad Road in Bhajanpura on May 19, 2020, when a tractor coming from the wrong side at high speed hit him. He sustained grievous injuries and later succumbed at the hospital.

Relying on the testimony of an eyewitness, the tribunal held that the accident occurred due to the rash and negligent driving of the individual behind the tractor.

It rejected the insurance company’s contention that the attached trolley, which was allegedly uninsured, had caused the accident, saying the evidence clearly showed the tractor hit the victim.

The tribunal also noted that the driver and owner chose not to contest the proceedings and did not challenge the eyewitness’ account, warranting an adverse inference against them.

(PTI)

Shaheen Bagh grave reuse plea dismissed by court

A Delhi court has upheld the dismissal of a man’s plea for a temporary injunction against the reuse of his wife’s grave, where she was buried in April 2021, by the management of the Shaheen Bagh graveyard, saying it would create a private right on the scarce public land meant to be utilised for the needs of society.

The court, however, clarified that its observations were confined to the issue of interim relief and would not affect the appellant’s right to lead evidence before the trial court during the pendency of the suit.

District Judge Atul Ahlawat was hearing a plea filed by M Basharat Hussain against the October 8, 2025 order of a trial court refusing the plea against the Management Committee of Jamiat Ulema-i-Hind and the graveyard caretaker.

The appellant had sought protection of the grave of his wife, who was buried at the Shaheen Bagh graveyard in April 2021, contending that under Muslim personal law, a grave could not be reopened or reused until the body had completely decomposed.

The management committee had argued that the graveyard was facing an acute shortage of burial space and that reuse of graves, undertaken with dignity and in accordance with accepted religious practice, was permissible in cases of necessity.

In an order dated July 10, the court said, “The trial court had correctly appreciated the facts in the background of the applicable laws and this court does not find any perversity or arbitrariness in the impugned order.

“Therefore, there is no merit in the present appeal and the same is hereby dismissed. The impugned order is accordingly upheld”. The appellant had argued that disturbing the grave before seven years have passed would violate the dignity of the deceased and fundamental rights guaranteed under the Constitution.

(PTI)

High Court seeks reply from UP Govt on petition against Ashutosh Brahmachari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has sought a reply from the Uttar Pradesh Government on a writ petition alleging that the petitioner was facing threats after he refused to lodge a false case against Swami Avimukteshwaran and Saraswati under pressure from Ashutosh Brahmachari.

Brahmachari, who had earlier filed a complaint against Saraswati, had said in June that he had filed a “fake suit” under pressure from Ramchandra Das, the mahant of Deva Ashram in Mathura.

The petitioner before the high court, Ramashankar Dixit, also alleged that when he refused to budge under pressure, he was threatened



with dire consequences.

The petitioner has also sought protection from police and moved the high court seeking passing of appropriate direction in this connection. A two-judge bench comprising Justice JJ Munir and

No more excuses: Supreme Court’s right to walk verdict comes into play for monsoon havoc



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

Every monsoon, major Indian cities face a familiar crisis: waterlogged streets, collapsed infrastructure, massive traffic gridlocks, and tragic losses of life. While extreme weather sets the stage, the recurring chaos heavily exposes the systemic failures of local civic bodies.

Historically, when a city floods and someone drowns, the state easily passes the buck, blaming “unprecedented rainfall” or an “act of God.” However, the recent landmark Supreme Court judgment (Maniyar Iliyaz v. P. Ayyappan, June 19, 2026) has emerged as a massive game-changer. The case arose from the heart-breaking death of a 5-year-old child who was run over by a tanker because there was no footpath, forcing him and his father to walk directly on the dangerous main road.

By declaring the “Right to Walk” on safe, demarcated footpaths as a Fundamental Right under Article 19(1)(d) (Right to Movement) and Article 21 (Right to Life), the Supreme Court provided the exact legal bridge needed to hold civic bodies accountable for monsoon havoc.

The connection between that judgment and the current crisis created by the rains is direct and profound. The Supreme Court effectively shattered the traditional state defence of natural inevitability by ruling that providing a safe environment is a “Positive Mandate” of the State.

This means municipal bodies cannot just wait for a disaster to happen and dismiss it as an unavoidable accident. By elevating basic civic infrastructure to the status of a Fundamental Right, the Supreme Court has made it clear that the state has an absolute duty to ensure its public spaces are safe.

When the monsoons arrive, the predictable failure to manage stormwater drains, clear debris, and secure open hazards is no longer just poor governance; it is a direct violation of our fundamental right to stay safe and alive. The Supreme Court’s mandate on civic safety makes it crucial for citizens to audit the massive financial resources allocated to local representatives.

Every year, thousands of crores are disbursed across three distinct tiers of governance, meant specifically for the development of the immediate neighbourhood, assembly, and parliamentary constituency.

At the absolute grassroots, a local Municipal Corporator



is allocated Ward Development Funds by the city’s municipal corporation. When streetlights fail, open potholes trigger accidents, or local blockages cause waterlogging on a specific street, the Corporator has a direct, dedicated fund to fix them instantly.

Moving up, every Member of the Legislative Assembly (MLA) receives the MLALADS fund (Vidhayak Nidhi), which ranges between ₹2 crore and ₹5 crore annually, depending on the state. If an entire neighbourhood lacks a proper stormwater drainage network, or if a primary connecting road lacks a safe footpath, the MLA has the direct financial capacity to build it.

At the national level, a Member of Parliament (MP) is allocated ₹5 crore every single year under the MPLADS scheme. Managed by the District Magistrate, these funds are designed for long-term, large-scale public safety installations and major civic

interventions spanning the entire parliamentary constituency. This is where public money meets a strict legal requirement. In the past, citizens could only request that politicians spend these development funds, and there was no way to force them.

Now, because the Supreme Court has made civic safety a fundamental right, spending these funds is no longer a political favour—it is a strict legal duty. Consequently, this Supreme Court verdict (Maniyar Iliyaz v P Ayyappan) does not just stop in New Delhi; it opens a massive door for every State High Court across the country.

Because the apex court has elevated civic safety to a Fundamental Right, High Courts no longer have to wait for the slow wheels of state governments to turn. They now have the explicit constitutional backing to step in, take control, and demand immediate answers from local municipal corporations.

Delhi court upholds 2-year jail term for man in 2016 Connaught Place hit-and-run case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has upheld the two-year prison sentence awarded to a man in a 2016 hit-and-run case in Connaught Place here.

Additional Sessions Judge Shefali Barnala Tandon was hearing the appeal of Rohit Kumar, who had been convicted by a magistrate in February 2025 under IPC sections 279 (rash driving) and 304A (causing death by negligence).

According to the prosecution, the case dates back to July 7, 2016, when Kumar’s car hit another car at the Connaught Place’s outer circle and rammed into a pedestrian, Kundan, who later succumbed of head injuries.

The prosecution said Kumar had fled the scene immediately after the accident. In an order dated July 1, the court said, “The subsequent conduct of a driver plays an important role while sentencing him for the offences of rash and negligent driving. Fleeing from the accident site without providing help is considered a punishable hit-and-run, strictly prohibited by law.”



It said under the Motor Vehicles Act provision, drivers are legally obligated to stop immediately and take all reasonable steps to take the injured person to the nearest medical hospital, but, in the present case, the appellant fled away immediately after causing the accident.

“With the ocular evidence, medical evidence as well as documentary evidence proved on record, it is held that the prosecution has been able to prove its case beyond any reasonable doubt

against the appellant/accused for the offence under sections 279 and 304A of the IPC,” the court said.

Rejecting Kumar’s plea for leniency, the court upheld the trial court’s concurrent sentences of two years of simple imprisonment along with a fine of ₹10,000 for the offence under Section 304A of the IPC, and three months imprisonment with a fine of ₹1,000 under Section 279 of the IPC.

It directed that a copy of this order be sent to the magistrate for execution of sentence and necessary compliance on Monday. In its order the court noted the testimony of an on-duty police officer, who testified that the car was being driven in a “zig-zag manner” at very high speed and dragged the victim for some distance on the footpath.

The court also considered the mechanical inspection report of the offending vehicle, which showed the front bumper dislocated and the airbags deployed.

SC to hear SEBI’s plea against SAT relief to SICCL managers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on July 13 a plea by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) challenging a part of the Securities Appellate Tribunal order granting relief to managers and the company secretary of Sahara India Commercial Corporation Ltd (SICCL).

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana will hear the plea of the market regulator.

Besides SEBI’s plea, the top court has listed all the pending Sahara matters, including the



return of monies to investors, for hearing.

On June 18, the top court agreed to hear the matter and issued notices to the four officials of the Sahara

group, tagging the matter with the pending cases related to the company.

The top court, while seeking their response, had asked them to file their

counter-affidavits by July 13.

On March 9, the tribunal upheld regulatory action by the SEBI against SICCL and dismissed appeals filed by the company and its directors in connection with the alleged illegal issuance of Optionally Fully Convertible Debentures (OFCDs).

The three-member SAT bench had ruled that the OFCDs issued by SICCL between 1998 and 2008 constituted a public offer, bringing them within SEBI’s regulatory jurisdiction.

The tribunal had said that the SICCL mobilised around ₹14,106 crore from nearly 1.98 crore investors through these debentures during the period.



Thane court acquits tennis coach of raping minor girl

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court has acquitted a tennis coach accused of raping and impregnating a 14-year-old student, observing that the girl’s post-incident conduct and continued training with him without complaint rebutted the legal presumption of guilt against the accused.

The victim’s conduct after the alleged incident cast doubt on the reliability of her testimony, Special Judge (for POCSO Act cases) Premal S Vithalani said in the order passed on July 10.

He noted that her decision to continue training with the coach without lodging any complaint undermined the credibility of her testimony, making it unsafe to convict the accused solely on her statement.

The court cleared the 40-year-old accused, a Navi Mumbai resident, of all charges under the Indian Penal Code and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, citing major inconsistencies and lack of corroborative evidence.

According to the prosecu-

tion, the Class 9 student alleged that the accused sexually assaulted her forcibly twice near a tennis court in a residential housing society in Thane in August and September 2023.

The matter came to light in October 2023 when she complained of abdominal pain, and medical scans revealed she was seven weeks pregnant, leading to a medical termination of the pregnancy. The court, however, pointed out that the prosecution failed to establish a solid foundation for its case.

“It cannot be disputed that no presumption is absolute and every presumption is rebuttable. It cannot be countenanced that presumption under Section 29 of POCSO Act is absolute. It would come into operation only when prosecution is first able to establish facts that would form the foundation for presumption under Sec 29 of POCSO Act to operate,” it said.

The court noted that despite receiving sex education at her international school on how to report sexual harassment, the survivor continued interacting normally and training with the coach.

considering the issues raised in the plea. While hearing the matter on January 19, the top court said it would interfere with the “unpredictable fluctuations” in airfares and flagged the exorbitant rise during festivals.

The top court had termed the exorbitant rise of airfares by the airlines as “exploitation” and asked the Centre and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) to file their replies on the plea.

The plea claimed that all private airlines have, without any credible justification, reduced the free check-in baggage allowance for economy class passengers from 25 kg to 15 kg, “thereby converting what was earlier part of the ticketed service into a new revenue stream”.

It said the “new policy of permitting only a single piece

for check-in and the absence of any rebate, compensation or benefit to passengers who do not avail themselves of check-in baggage demonstrates the arbitrary and discriminatory nature of the measure”. The plea claimed that currently, no authority has the power to review or cap airfares or ancillary fees, allowing the airlines to exploit consumers through hidden charges and unpredictable pricing.

It said the “unregulated, opaque and exploitative conduct of airlines manifesting in arbitrary fare hikes, unilateral reduction of services, absence of on-ground grievance redressal and unjustified dynamic pricing algorithms directly infringes upon citizens’ fundamental rights to equality, freedom of movement and life with dignity”.

FROM THE WORLD

CHINA

Brahmaputra dam safety questioned

A study by Chinese geologists has found that an active fault line beneath the world's largest hydropower project on the Brahmaputra River in Tibet could affect its structural stability, raising questions over Beijing's repeated claims that it would help prevent disasters in the region. The project is close to the Indian border in Arunachal Pradesh.

The scientists said a fracture in the Earth's crust in the eastern Himalayan region could significantly affect the structural integrity of the massive hydropower project's infrastructure, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported on Thursday.

According to the researchers, prolonged fault activity has fractured and weakened the surrounding rock formations, making the foundations and structural stability of nearby engineering projects more vulnerable to damage. (PTI)

USA

Indian American shot dead

Indian American Sheetal Wrzesien, a former Google executive, was shot dead by her husband in Cobb County in Georgia in the US, a local media report said. Wrzesien's son Jason was injured in the shootout that took place at the couple's home at Laurel Creek Trail.

The accused, 56-year-old Kirk B Wrzesien, was arrested on Tuesday night from the family's residence in Cobb County, near Atlanta.

Joanne Anderson, who has lived on the street for more than 20 years and raised her daughter there, said she was caught off guard by the commotion, Atlanta News First reported. "I didn't know what was going on. I didn't know if someone had a heart attack or what had happened," Anderson said. According to the Cobb County Police Department, officers responded to reports of gunfire at the couple's home in Smyrna shortly before 8 pm. (PTI)

Typhoon Bavi weakens but still brings strong winds, rain to China

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Beijing

Typhoon Bavi weakened Sunday to a tropical storm hours after making land-fall in eastern China's Zhejiang province, but was still bringing days of strong winds and heavy rain to parts of China.

Its intensity continued to weaken as it moved northwestward across eastern China into the province of Anhui as of Sunday afternoon, according to China's national weather centre.

Strong winds and heavy rain are expected to impact many eastern and northeastern Chinese cities on Sunday and Monday, China's National Meteorological Centre said, adding that heavy to torrential rain was recorded Sunday afternoon in provinces including Anhui. In Zhejiang province, more than 2.2 million people were evacuated due to Bavi, according to state media. Shanghai evacuated over 290,000 people from at-risk areas, while Fujian province



evacuated more than 180,000 people.

In the coastal city of Yueqing in Zhejiang province, more than 1,300 trees were toppled, including at least 700 uprooted, according to state broadcaster CCTV.

Shanghai's Pudong International Airport and Hongqiao International Airport were expected to cancel around 653 inbound and

outbound flights due to Bavi, the official Xinhua News Agency said. Bavi passed north of Taiwan on Saturday but did not make a direct landfall. Taiwan's fire department said at least 134 people across the island were injured, some sustaining injuries while riding motorcycles or bicycles in strong winds or due to slippery road surfaces.

Shooting near Toronto street festival kills 2 people, wounds 5, police say



ROB GILLIES

■ Toronto

A shooting near a Toronto street festival killed two people and wounded five on Saturday, prompting police to warn of an active shooter before later saying the scene was secure.

Toronto Police spokesperson Shannon Eames said there were two deceased and five others with gunshot wounds after the shooting near St Clair Avenue West and Arlington Avenue, where the Salsa on St Clair Festival was underway.

Officers urged the public to avoid the area while they responded. Police later said the scene had been secured but cautioned that a suspect or suspects had not been appre-

hended. Valerie Rodriguez said she was sitting next to a restaurant on Saturday night when she saw people screaming and running.

"A bunch of people ... told us to lay down onto the floor," she said. "We got scared because we didn't know exactly what was happening."

Patsy Gutierrez, a vendor at the festival, said she was serving customers when she saw "a huge wave" of people running.

"Everybody started getting frantic and then we stopped serving," she said. "I don't think it should be something that's happening in these type of events."

A large police presence remained in the area near the

festival, an annual celebration of Latin American culture that draws thousands of people to the city's St Clair West neighborhood for live music, dancing, food and cultural performances.

"I am devastated by the senseless violence at the Salsa on St. Clair Festival that has claimed two lives and injured others," Ontario Premier Doug Ford said in a social media post. "My thoughts are with the victims, their families and everyone affected."

Toronto, Canada's largest city, is among North America's safest major cities. Fatal shootings, particularly those involving multiple victims in public, are relatively rare. (AP)

Bangladesh reports 44 deaths due to floods; capital Dhaka deluged

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dhaka

At least 44 people have died in flood and landslide incidents in a week, officials said Sunday even as rivers remained above danger level leading to displacement of over 2.5 lakh families across Bangladesh.

Overnight torrential rains — 76 mm from 12 midnight till 6 am — inundated several areas and paralysed life in capital Dhaka even as the government deployed army troops alongside navy and air force personnel to carry out relief operations in seven worst-hit districts along with local humanitarian agencies.

"Since July 5, officially 44 flood related deaths were recorded until Saturday evening. We estimate that some 2,67,000 families



have been affected so far," a Disaster Management Ministry spokesman said here.

Several of the casualties were caused by landslides while most others either drowned or were washed away due to floods and overflowing rivers, the spokesperson said.

Nearly 44,457 deluge displaced people took refuge at over 1,100 makeshift flood shelters in affected areas, mostly in northeastern and

southeastern regions. "The deluge marooned members of an estimated 2,67,918 families in the affected areas," the official said.

Bangladesh has divided the lower riparian deltaic country, criss-crossed by 1,415 rivers, in four major basins. The onrush of waters from the upstream coupled with heavy monsoon rains until Saturday inflated rivers in northeastern Meghna Basin and southeastern Hill Basin.

US Senator Lindsey Graham, close Trump ally, dies at 71

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Washington

US Republican Senator Lindsey Graham, one of President Donald Trump's closest allies and an influential voice on American foreign policy, has died after what his office described as a "brief and sudden illness". He was 71.

Graham, who represented South Carolina in the Senate for more than two decades, was among the Republican Party's most outspoken supporters of Ukraine in its war against Russia and a leading advocate of tougher sanctions on Moscow.

Despite a bitter rivalry with Trump during the 2016 Republican presidential campaign, he went on to become one of his closest political allies.

Graham was a vocal critic of India's purchases of Russian oil amid the Ukraine war and repeatedly called for sanctions against countries, including India, buying Russian energy.

Earlier this year, Graham said Trump had "greenlit" a bipartisan legislation he had worked on for months that would authorise the US president to impose tariffs of up to 500 per cent on countries, including India, buying Russian oil.

He had earlier cited US tariffs on India as "a good example of how things can



change" while claiming that New Delhi had dramatically reduced its purchases of Russian oil.

"Clearly, the pressure we're applying to (Russian President Vladimir) Putin to come to the peace table and stop massive attacks against Ukraine is not working. President Trump's idea of going after Putin's oil customers who prop up his war machine should be pursued with vigour by the US and Europe," Graham had said. His office announced his death in a statement posted on X.

"On the evening of Saturday, July 11, US Senator Lindsey Graham passed away from a brief and sudden illness," the statement said. "Senator Graham's family appreciates prayers at this time and asks for privacy during this incredibly difficult period."

Later, President Trump said in a social media post:

"Senator Lindsey Graham, one of the greatest people and Senators I have ever known, is dead! He was always working, and was a true American Patriot. Lindsey will be greatly missed!!!! DETAILS AND ARRANGEMENTS TO FOLLOW. So sad!"

NBC News reported that Graham was scheduled to appear on its Meet the Press programme on Sunday following a recent visit to Ukraine, underscoring the suddenness of his death.

The BBC reported that Graham was working on a revised version of the Russia sanctions bill during his latest visit to Kyiv, saying it would give "tools to President Trump to end this war".

Born in South Carolina, Graham was first elected to the US House of Representatives in 1994 before winning election to the Senate in 2002.

He took office as senator in January 2003 and was

seeking another term this year.

He also served as chairman of the Senate Budget Committee. A lawyer by training, Graham also served in the US Air Force and Air Force Reserve, retiring with the rank of colonel.

Although he sharply criticised Trump during the 2016 Republican presidential primaries, the two later forged a close political relationship, with Graham emerging as one of the president's most dependable allies in Congress. He was a strong supporter of Trump's judicial appointments, immigration policies and much of his foreign policy agenda.

"He's outstanding. He's been at my side for a long time," The Washington Post quoted Trump as saying at a tele-rally for Graham last month. Recalling their once-bitter rivalry, the president added: "After that fight was over, we were best of friends, and he's helped me as much as anybody in the Senate."

Graham was also a staunch supporter of Israel and advocated for strong US-Israel ties throughout his senate career. Leaders of NATO member states, Ukraine and Israel paid tribute to Graham on Sunday, remembering him as a friend, partner and a strong advocate of transatlantic ties who remained an influential voice on US foreign policy for decades.

Ukrainian Prime Minister to step down as Zelenskyy announces Government reshuffle

SAMYA KULLAB

■ Kyiv



Ukrainian PM Yulia Svyrydenko arrives for a meeting with Lithuania's President Gitanas Nausėda at the Presidential palace in Vilnius, Lithuania. AP

in July 2025 at the age of 39 after playing a lead role in securing a mineral agreement between Ukraine and the US, seen as an important way of tying US interests to Ukraine's security.

Zelenskyy announced her resignation in a post saying that Ukraine was "changing its political strategy."

He also said he had offered Svyrydenko the opportunity to lead "a new,

important area" in Ukraine's relations with a key international partner.

"Each priority area of foreign policy will be assigned to a specific person with substantial experience who is capable of implementing what we agree on at the leaders' level and what the Ukrainian people expect," Zelenskyy said, describing the impending reshuffle. The Ukrainian leader also said there would be changes among the top ranks of Ukraine's law enforcement agencies.

Ukraine continues strikes against Russian oil sites. Elsewhere, a Ukrainian attack in southwest Russia killed one person and wounded three more, local officials said Sunday, as Kyiv's forces continued to bombard Russia's oil facilities.

The head of Russia's Samara region, Gov. Vyacheslav Fedorishchev, said that a child was among the

injured. He also said that residential homes and apartment buildings were damaged in the strike, as well as an unspecified "industrial site."

Russian media outlets reported that the attack's target was the region's Syzran Oil Refinery, with many sharing images that appeared to show plumes of black smoke rising over the site. The refinery, which is owned by oil and gas giant Rosneft and sits some 800 kilometers (500 miles) east of the border, has been a repeated target for Kyiv's forces.

Meanwhile the governor of Russia's Rostov region, Yuri Slyusar, said that a tanker had been damaged in a drone attack in the Azov-Black Sea maritime canal. The tanker was empty and there is no threat of an oil spill, Slyusar said. (AP)

Israeli fire in Gaza kills 5, including a girl child: Health officials

WAFAA SHURAF/A
NATALIE MELZER

■ Deir al-Balah (Gaza Strip)

Israeli fire in Gaza on Sunday killed at least five Palestinians, including a 9-year-old girl, and wounded others, according to local health officials.

A drone strike on a blacksmith shop in Gaza City's Sabra neighborhood killed at least four Palestinians and wounded another, according to officials at Shifa hospital, where the casualties were taken. The Israeli military acknowledged striking the area, saying it targeted "terrorist infrastructure," without elaborating.

Palestinians received an evacuation order from the military following the first strikes. Roughly an hour later, intense airstrikes targeted the same blacksmith shop.



Also on Sunday, Israeli gunfire killed 9-year-old Tala Abu Matar in a displacement camp in central Gaza, according to officials at the Health Ministry. The Israeli military said it was unaware of such an incident.

Israeli strikes have lessened considerably since a ceasefire took effect on Oct 10, but they continue almost daily. Israel's military says it targets Hamas and other militants, often asserting

they were planning attacks. The strikes have also killed many civilians.

At least 1,098 Palestinians, including at least 260 children, have been killed since the ceasefire, according to Gaza's Health Ministry. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed in that time. The Oct 7, 2023, attack by Hamas-led militants that sparked the war killed some 1,200 people in Israel and saw 251 others taken hostage. (AP)

14 nations, EU reaffirm 2016 ruling invalidating China's claims in South China Sea

JIM GOMEZ

■ Manila

The US, the UK and a dozen other Western and Asian countries reasserted on Sunday that China's expansive claims in the South China Sea are illegal based on a 2016 arbitration ruling.

A joint statement issued by the 14 nations said they rejected "destabilising" actions in the disputed waters that threaten regional stability. The 27-nation European Union released a separate statement, reaffirming the ruling as a "landmark decision in the peaceful set-

tlement of disputes".

The statements commemorated a July 12, 2016, arbitration ruling by a tribunal established in The Hague under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, saying the landmark decision is "is final and legally binding".

China reiterated Sunday that the ruling was "null and void and has no binding force" and Beijing "neither accepts nor recognises it".

China refused to join the arbitration initiated by the Philippines in 2013 after a tense standoff in the contested waters a year earlier that



In this image made from video provided by the Armed Forces of the Philippines, a Chinese coast guard ship uses water cannon on a Philippine resupply vessel Unaiyah May 4 as it approaches Second Thomas Shoal, locally called Ayungin shoal, at the disputed South China Sea on March 23, 2024. AP

ended with Beijing effectively seizing a disputed shoal. Beijing rejected the 2016 ruling and continues to defend its claims to virtually the entire sea passage, a key global trade route that has long been feared as one of Asia's most active flash-points. The areas has been the scene of repeated territorial standoffs involving China and the Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei and Taiwan.

"We reaffirm the Arbitral Tribunal's decision that there is no legal basis for China's expansive maritime claims in

the South China Sea, including those based on 'historic rights'," the US-led statement said.

The arbitration tribunal largely decided in favour of the Philippines, ruling then that under the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea, "there was no legal basis for China to claim historic rights to resources" in the South China Sea outside of its regular territorial areas recognised under the convention.

The convention, largely regarded as the treaty governing the world's oceans and seas, took effect in 1994

and has been ratified by more than 170 countries and parties, including China and the Philippines.

In addition to the US and Britain, the other countries listed in Sunday's statement were the Philippines, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, Canada, Germany, Italy, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Romania and Slovenia.

"We reiterate our strong opposition to any destabilizing or unilateral actions including by force or coercion that threaten peace and stability in the region," they said. (AP)

US to seek extradition of Bishnoi, Nagra, says official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Washington

The US will seek extradition of Lawrence Bishnoi, accused of ordering the killing of Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar in Canada and several other crimes in America, an official said Sunday.

The US Department of Justice will also seek extradition of Gurinderjit Singh Nagra, for his involvement in a USD 4,00,000 extortion case in the US, alleging that he worked in concert with the Bishnoi and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria gangs to target families based in the US.

Nijjar, a Canadian citizen, was killed in Surrey in British Columbia, Canada, on June 18, 2023. An official in the US Attorney's Office replied in affirmative in response to questions on extradition of Bishnoi and Nagra but did not elaborate.

"Yes. Beyond that, we have no additional comment," Ciaran McEvoy, Public Affairs Officer, US Attorney's Office, Central District of California, said in an e-mail response to PTI. In a joint operation earlier this week, law enforcement agencies in the United States, Canada, and Europe arrested 24 persons – 11 of them in California – connected with three India-based transnational organised crime groups charged with a litany of criminal acts.

In total, the US Department of Justice charged 37 people in the indictment as part of its 'Operation Hardball'.



The Pioneer
EXCLUSIVE



Dr. WAIEL AWWAD

How do you assess the current state of India-Egypt relations?

In order to be able to answer this question, we need to put in the context of a rich civilizational connections between Egypt and India, which started since millennia, and could be traced back to the 5th Dynasty of Ancient Egyptians. I would say that India-Egypt relations are today stronger than they have been in decades, due to the fact that we have visionary statesmen at the helm of the two countries, President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi in Egypt and Prime Minister Narendra Modi in India. What makes the Strategic Partnership, signed in 2023, special is that it is built on both history and the future. Our countries have been characterized with a special sense of duality and friendship in our contemporary history, starting from Saad Zaghloul Pasha who was an inspiration to the great Mahatma Gandhi, in their joint struggle for independence, to President Gamal Abdel Nasser and Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, in the 20th century, to today's duality of el-Sisi-Modi joint vision to transform that historic goodwill into a modern Strategic Partnership. There is growing political trust, frequent high-level exchanges, expanding defence and security cooperation, increasing trade and investment, and close coordination in multi-lateral forums.

As leading voices of the Global South, both Egypt and India believe that international challenges require dialogue, inclusiveness, and respect for international law.

Our economic relationship is equally promising. India is among Egypt's most important economic partners, with Indian companies investing across manufacturing, chemicals, renewable energy, information technology, and agriculture, with a gross investment reaching approximately \$3.7 Billion. At the same time, Egypt offers India a strategic gateway to Africa, the Middle East, and Europe through its unique geographic location and world-class infrastructure.

But I believe the greatest potential still lies ahead. We are now looking beyond traditional cooperation towards joint manufacturing, digital technologies, green hydrogen, maritime connectivity, food security, pharmaceuticals, and innovation. These are areas where our strengths complement each other remarkably well. So, I see Egypt-India relations not simply as a bilateral partnership, but as a partnership with regional and global significance-one that contributes to stability, prosperity, and sustainable development across the Global South."

Therefore, India and Egypt are not merely renewing an old friendship; we are building a strategic partnership for the twenty-first century-connecting Asia, Africa, and Europe through shared interests, shared values, and shared ambition. The relationship has moved beyond diplomacy; it is now a comprehensive strategic partnership driven by political trust, economic complementarity, and a common vision for a more balanced and inclusive global order."

What are the top priorities for the Strategic Partnership?

Our Strategic Partnership is guided by a very practical vision: translating political goodwill into tangible deliverables and benefits for our peoples. I would highlight five key priorities.

- First, economic cooperation. Our objective is not simply to increase trade from its current \$6 Billion to \$12

Billion, but to build a resilient value chains capable of adapting to very turbulent and volatile geostrategic and geo-economic global landscape. We want to encourage greater investment, joint manufacturing, and industrial partnerships that create jobs and enhance competitiveness in both countries.

- Second, connectivity and logistics. Egypt's strategic location at the crossroads of Africa, Asia, and Europe, together with India's manufacturing strength, creates enormous opportunities. We see Egypt as a natural gateway for Indian companies seeking to reach European, African, and Middle Eastern markets more efficiently.
- Third, technology and innovation. India has emerged as a global leader in digital public infrastructure DPI, information technology, fintech, and start-ups. Egypt offers a young, skilled workforce and an expanding ICT ecosystem. Together, we can cooperate in artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, digital services, electronics, and innovation.
- Fourth, energy and sustainability. Clean energy, particularly green hydrogen and renewable energy, is becoming a major pillar of our cooperation. Both countries are committed to supporting the global energy transition while ensuring energy security.
- Fifth, people-to-people ties. Lasting partnerships are built not only by governments but also by businesses, universities, researchers, tourists, artists, and young people. Expanding educational exchanges, cultural cooperation, tourism, and academic collaboration will deepen the foundations of our relationship for generations to come.

Beyond these five priorities, we also work closely on maritime security, food security, healthcare, pharmaceuticals, and defense cooperation-areas that contribute to regional stability and mutual prosperity. Ultimately, our Strategic Partnership is about combining India's scale and innovation with Egypt's strategic location and regional connectivity. Together, we can create opportunities that neither country could achieve alone."

Where do you see India-Egypt relations by 2030?

By 2030, I believe India and Egypt can become one of the most consequential strategic partnerships linking Asia, Africa, Europe, and the Middle East. I envision a relationship that goes far beyond traditional diplomacy. We should aim to become partners in production, innovation, connectivity, and sustainable development. Economically, I hope to see a significant expansion in bilateral trade and investment, with Indian companies increasingly using Egypt as a manufacturing, logistical and export hub for Africa, Europe, and the Arab world, while Egyptian companies deepen their presence in the dynamic Indian market. Our ambition should not simply be to trade more, but to produce together and compete together in global markets.

At the geopolitical level, I expect our coordination to become even closer and frequent. India and Egypt are two ancient civilizations, two major developing economies, and two responsible regional powers who share the responsibility of calling for peace, stability, tolerance and co-existence. Together, we can play an important role in advancing peace, supporting sustainable development, strengthening food and energy security, and ensuring that the voice of the Global South is heard in global decision-making. Most importantly, I hope that by 2030, the relationship will be measured not only by government agreements, but by the number of students studying in each other's universities,



ties, entrepreneurs launching joint ventures, tourists discovering each other's rich heritage, researchers collaborating on innovation, and young people building lifelong partnerships.

Shortly, I hope that by 2030, people would stop asking what India and Egypt can do for each other, and instead ask what India and Egypt achieved together for the world

How can bilateral trade be significantly increased?

The potential for expanding India-Egypt trade is enormous because our economies are highly complementary rather than competitive. The question is no longer whether trade can grow-it is how quickly we can unlock its full potential.

First, we need to encourage greater investment-led trade. When Indian companies manufacture in Egypt, they gain efficient access to markets across Africa, Europe, and the Arab region through Egypt's extensive network of free trade agreements. Likewise, Egyptian companies can use India as a gateway to one of the world's largest and fastest-growing consumer markets.

Second, we should move from trading products to building integrated value chains. Instead of simply exporting raw

materials or finished goods, our companies should jointly manufacture pharmaceuticals, automobiles, textiles, chemicals, food products, electronics, and renewable energy components. This creates greater value, resilience, and employment in both countries.

Third, connectivity is key. Egypt's strategic location and the Suez Canal make it one of the world's most important logistics hubs. By combining India's manufacturing strength with Egypt's logistics and industrial infrastructure, specially in the Suez Canal Zone (SCZ) we can reduce transit times, improve supply chain resilience, and enhance the competitiveness of Indian exports to Europe and Africa.

Fourth, we should deepen cooperation in the digital economy. Digital trade, fintech, IT services, e-commerce, start-up collaboration, and digital public infrastructure represent some of the fastest-growing areas of our partnership.

Finally, the private sector must be at the heart of this relationship. Governments create the enabling environment, but businesses create trade. We therefore encourage more business-to-business partnerships, regular CEO forums, trade missions, and investment facilitation mechanisms.

Which sectors offer the best opportunities for Indian investors in Egypt?

Egypt offers Indian investors a unique value proposition. We combine a strategic geographic location, a large and youthful talent pool, competitive operating costs, modern infrastructure, and preferential access to more than 70 countries through an extensive network of free trade agreements. For Indian companies, investing in Egypt is not simply an investment in one market-it is an investment in access to Africa, the Middle East, and Europe. I see seven sectors with particularly strong potential.

First, manufacturing and industrial production. Egypt is an ideal base for Indian manufacturers in sectors such as automotive components, engineering products, chemicals, and consumer goods, enabling them to serve regional markets efficiently.

Second, information and communication technology. Egypt has a rapidly growing digital economy, a highly skilled multilingual workforce, and a vibrant start-up ecosystem. There are excellent opportunities for collaboration in artificial intelligence, software development, business process outsourcing, fintech, cybersecurity, and digital public services.

Third, renewable energy and green hydrogen. Egypt has exceptional solar and wind resources, world-class infrastructure, and a strategic location for exporting clean energy. This creates significant opportunities for Indian companies involved in green hydrogen, electrolyzers, renewable technologies, and sustainable industrial projects.

Fourth, pharmaceuticals and healthcare. India's global leadership in pharmaceuticals complements Egypt's position as a manufacturing and distribution hub for Africa and the Arab region. Joint production can enhance healthcare access while opening new export markets.

Fifth, logistics, ports, and supply chains. The Suez Canal and Egypt's integrated ports and industrial zones provide a natural platform for logistics, warehousing, value-added manufacturing, and regional distribution.

Sixth, agriculture and food processing. Food security has become a global priority. There is considerable scope for cooperation in agricultural technology, food processing, cold-chain logistics, and agribusiness.

Seventh, tourism and hospitality. Egypt's unique cultural heritage and growing tourism sector offer opportunities in hospitality, hotel development, entertainment, and tourism services.

How can Egypt serve as India's gateway to Africa and Europe?

Egypt is uniquely positioned to become India's natural gateway to both Africa and Europe because it combines geography, connectivity, trade agreements, and industrial capacity in a way that few countries can match. First, Egypt sits at the crossroads of three continents and controls the Suez Canal, through which around 12% of global trade and roughly 30% of global container traffic passes. This gives Indian companies unparalleled access to one of the world's busiest trade corridors. Second, Egypt offers Indian manufacturers preferential access to over 2.5 billion consumers through an extensive network of free trade agreements, including:

- African Continental Free Trade Area, covering 54 African countries.
- Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa.
- Greater Arab Free Trade Area.
- The Association Agreement with the European Union.

This means that products manufactured in Egypt can reach African, European, and Arab markets more competitively than exports shipped directly from India. Third, Indian companies can leverage the Suez Canal Economic Zone as a regional manufacturing and logistics hub. By producing in Egypt, they can shorten supply chains, reduce shipping times to Europe by several days, lower logistics costs, and diversify production beyond Asia.

What incentives does Egypt offer to Indian businesses?

Egypt offers Indian businesses a compelling value proposition that goes far beyond tax incentives. It provides a combination of strategic location, market access, competitive costs, and government support that makes it one of the most attractive investment destinations in the region. First, Egypt has a modern investment framework under the General Authority for Investment and Free Zones, which provides streamlined, seamless procedures, investor support, and incentives for priority sectors.

Second, companies investing in Egypt can benefit from:

- Tax incentives for projects in strategic sectors and underdeveloped regions.
- Customs exemptions and simplified import procedures for production inputs in designated zones.
- Competitive land allocation in industrial and logistics parks.
- Access to well-developed free zones

and the Suez Canal Economic Zone, which offers integrated industrial, logistics, and port infrastructure.

Third, Egypt offers Indian investors something equally valuable: market access. Manufacturing in Egypt enables companies to export preferentially to:

- African Continental Free Trade Area.
- Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa.
- Greater Arab Free Trade Area.
- The European Union under Egypt's Association Agreement.

Egypt also offers:

- A young and skilled workforce with competitive labour costs.
- Reliable energy infrastructure and growing renewable energy capacity.
- Excellent maritime connectivity through the Suez Canal and modern Mediterranean and Red Sea ports.
- A rapidly expanding ICT ecosystem that supports digital industries, business services, and innovation.

Importantly, the relationship is already producing results. More than 55 Indian companies have established operations in Egypt across sectors such as chemicals, textiles, packaging, pharmaceuticals, automotive components, and renewable energy, demonstrating strong confidence in the Egyptian market.

How can India and Egypt cooperate in AI and digital transformation?

Artificial Intelligence and digital transformation represent one of the low-hanging fruits in the Egypt- India Strategic Partnership. India is a global leader in digital innovation, while Egypt is rapidly emerging as a regional digital hub connecting Africa, the Middle East, and Europe. Together, we can create solutions that serve not only our two countries, but the entire Global South. India has demonstrated how digital public infrastructure can transform governance, financial inclusion, healthcare, and education at scale. Egypt is undertaking an ambitious digital transformation agenda, investing heavily in smart government services, telecommunications, data centres, and digital skills. These strengths are highly complementary. There are five priority areas for cooperation:

- **AI research and innovation:** Establish joint AI research centres linking Egyptian and Indian universities and technology companies, focusing on healthcare, agriculture, climate resilience, language technologies, and smart cities.
- **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI):** Egypt can benefit from India's internationally recognised digital platforms in digital identity, digital payments, and e-governance, adapting them to local needs while sharing best practices with African partners.
- **IT and Business Process Outsourcing (BPO):** Egypt offers a multilingual workforce, competitive operating costs, and proximity to European and African markets. Indian IT companies can expand their regional operations from Egypt, making it a delivery hub for Europe, Africa, and the Middle East.
- **Semiconductors, cloud computing, and data centres:** India's growing electronics ecosystem can complement Egypt's strategic location, expanding investments in cloud infrastructure, cybersecurity, and regional data centres.
- **Digital skills and talent development:** Joint programmes in AI, cybersecurity, software engineering, and advanced digital technologies can prepare a new generation of innovators and entrepreneurs. Looking ahead, I also see opportunities for cooperation in AI governance.

Dr Wael Awwad is Secretary-General IACCIA & FICCI Arab Head

Read full interview on
www.dailypioneer.com

PROSPECT

Security Forces avert potential communal clash at Kanto Sabal

On July 11, 2026, in the afternoon hours, a crowd of nearly 600 to 700 persons attempted to advance towards Kanto Sabal, Imphal West district of Manipur where an illegal block has been set up by another community, Ministry of Defence said in a press release.

Indian Army columns promptly intervened, with Manipur Police. It separated the opposing groups and prevented the situation from escalating into a potential communal clash. During the intervention, the crowd resorted to stone-pelting. Despite the provocation, Security Forces exercised restraint, remained steadfast and successfully brought the situation under control. In the meantime, certain miscreants attempted to set fire to vacant houses in the area. The arson attempt was swiftly contained by the Army and police, thereby preventing further damage and ensuring no loss of life.

The situation is presently under control and Security Forces continue to maintain a close vigil in the area. (PNS)



Ex-servicemen outreach event held in Kohima

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

The Military Station Zakhama conducted an Ex-Servicemen (ESM) Outreach Programme on 09 July 2026 in Kohima district of Nagaland. The event was conducted for strengthening engagement with the veteran community and addressing issues concerning Ex-Servicemen and their dependents. The programme witnessed the participation of 24 Ex-Servicemen and four war widows from the region.



for the benefit of Ex-Servicemen, widows and their dependents.

The Officer-in-Charge, Pension Cell, delivered a briefing on recent policies and directives concerning veterans. He also updated the participants on the progress of the construction of the new facility being developed to enhance services and support for the veteran community.

An interactive open house session followed, providing Ex-Servicemen and widows an opportunity to raise concerns, discuss challenges and seek clarifications on matters affecting their welfare. The discussions facilitated direct interaction with the concerned authorities and helped identify issues requiring further attention.

The outreach programme concluded with a community lunch, fostering camaraderie and reinforcing the enduring bond between the Armed Forces and the veteran fraternity.

Airtel bets on financial services, cloud; ₹3.3 lakh cr invested: Mittal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After investing over ₹3.3 lakh crore in building digital infrastructure in the past decade, Bharti Airtel is betting big on financial services, data centres, and cloud for the next phase of growth, Chairman Sunil Bharti Mittal said in the company's annual report.

Bharti Airtel has announced ₹20,000-crore investment in non-banking financial company Airtel Money while its data centre Nxtra recently raised USD 1 billion (about ₹9,500 crore) as part of its plan to build 1 gigawatt capacity.

"Over the last few years, we took a calibrated approach to build new growth engines for Airtel. These bold bets yielded strong outcomes and have grown our conviction in three adjacencies where we believe Airtel has a clear right to win — financial services, data centres and Airtel Cloud," Mittal said in the report released late night on Saturday.

He said Airtel Money was granted the approval from the Reserve Bank of India to operate as a non-deposit taking Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC).

"This is a significant milestone for your company, as also, for the broader goal of



expanding the reach of financial inclusion in India.

"Airtel Money will be suitably capitalised over the years," Mittal said.

He said Nxtra is on track to build 1 GW of capacity over the next few years driven by demand from India's rapid digitisation, rising cloud adoption and increasing data localisation requirements.

"Our third growth engine, Airtel Cloud, is seeing encouraging early traction. Our sovereign, telco-grade cloud offering addresses an emerging need in the Indian market.

Airtel Cloud allows our customers to get access to world-class cloud offerings hosted and held in India and delivered in a cost-effective

manner," Mittal said.

He said Airtel has secured over 24 deals for cloud offering to customers.

Mittal said policies are in place to support cloud, AI and digital infrastructure that are expected to accelerate investments and strengthen the ecosystem.

"Building on this momentum, the long-term tax holiday laid out by the Government of India for cloud and AI-led data centre investments is a timely initiative, expected to catalyse sustained capital inflows into digital infrastructure, while assuring the people of India of sovereign, secure data flows," Mittal said.

The government expects to attract investments in the data centre space to cross

\$200 billion (over ₹18 lakh crore) this year.

"Over the last 10 years, your company has invested significantly with over ₹3.3 trillion in creating one of India's strongest digital infrastructure platforms. The emergence of the 5G economy is defining the next phase of growth, enabling new use cases across industries," Mittal said.

He said 5G is accelerating the shift towards high-speed, low-latency connectivity and unlocking new avenues for innovation through widespread network availability.

"Our 5G customer base has grown to 188 million. Airtel's 5G Plus network now carries half of all wireless data traffic on our network," Mittal added.

ICAI inaugurates global summit to strengthen India's leadership in Global Capability Centres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI), through its Global Trade & Services Committee, inaugurated the first edition of ICAI Global Orbit Summit 2026 in New Delhi today, marking the commencement of a nationwide series of summit dedicated to strengthening India's position as the global destination for Global Capability Centres (GCCs). The event was hosted by Northern Indian Regional Council of ICAI.

Organised under the theme "ICAI Global Orbit: From GCCs to Global Leadership", the Summit served as a strategic platform to foster dialogue, encourage innovation and generate actionable insights for



advancing India's GCC ecosystem, one of the fastest-growing pillars of the global services economy.

The Summit was inaugurated by CA Prasanna Kumar D, President, ICAI, in the presence of CA Charanjot Singh Nanda, Immediate Past President, ICAI; CA Sanjib Sanghi, Chairman, Global Trade & Services Committee; CA (Dr) Sanjeev Kumar Singhal, Central Council Member, ICAI and CA

hub for Global Capability Centres and Chartered Accountants have that expertise and professional strength to lead and drive GCCs globally, contributing to India's journey towards Viksit Bharat."

CA Sanjib Sanghi, Chairman, Global Trade & Services Committee, said, "India is home to over 2,100 Global Capability Centres (GCCs), employing nearly 2.36 million professionals and generating close to USD 100 billion in annual revenue. This represents a significant opportunity for the accountancy profession. The ICAI Global Summit Platform will serve as a dynamic forum for knowledge exchange, cross-industry collaboration, and policy dialogue, bringing together policymakers, industry leaders,

GCCs, academia, and the accountancy profession to shape the future of this rapidly evolving ecosystem."

The summit featured a series of thought-provoking sessions and dialogues aimed at shaping the future of GCCs in India. Eminent speakers and industry leaders shared practical perspectives and future-ready strategies on various aspects like Finance Innovation, AI & Automation, Data Privacy, ESG & Sustainable Development, GCC Setup & Strategy, Global Taxation, HR & Workforce, Marketing Strategy and Process Transformation. Industry experts shared actionable insights on emerging technologies, evolving regulations,

Indian Bank aims to recover ₹5,500 crore from bad loans during FY27: MD B Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Public sector lender Indian Bank is targeting up to ₹5,500 crore from the recovery of bad loans during the current financial year. "The recovery made during the first quarter was ₹1,885 crore, and the aim is to garner ₹4,500 crore to ₹5,500 crore under this head in FY27," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told PTI in an interaction. Of this, the Chennai-based bank hopes to realise ₹500 crore during the ongoing financial year from cases listed before NCLT.

Asked about the foreign currency deposit mobilisation drive started last month, he said the bank has collected \$140 million till July 9.

"My plan is to raise around \$2 billion in FCNR (B) deposits till September. It may seem high, but I already have a pipeline of \$1 billion," he said.

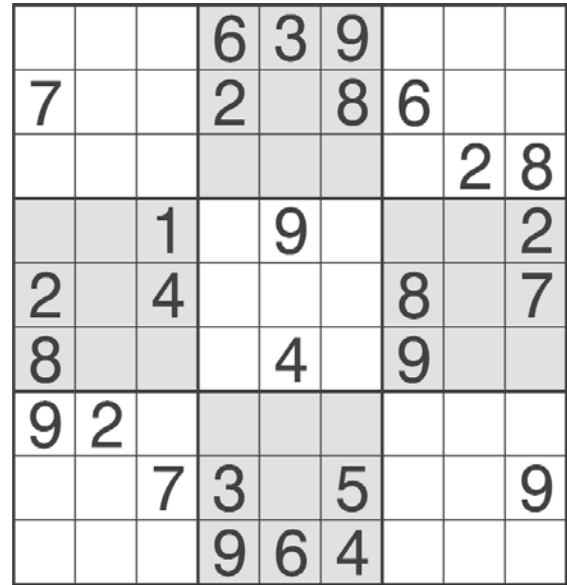
Indian Bank currently offers interest rates varying from 5.5-6.5 per cent on FCNR (B) deposits depending on tenure and amount. In a bid to attract foreign currency deposits by Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs) and Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs), Reserve Bank of India last month withdrew, till September 30, interest rate ceiling on fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits of 3-5 years' maturity.



The move came at a time when FCNR(B) deposit inflows weakened sharply, with net inflows dropping to just \$946 million in FY26 from \$7.1 billion in FY25. The RBI had, in 2013, introduced similar schemes when dollar outflows were high, triggered by the taper tantrum. Speaking about low-cost deposit mobilisation efforts of the bank, Kumar said the bank has witnessed a robust 15.3 per cent growth in Current Account and Savings Account (CASA) deposits during the first quarter.

It has increased to ₹3,19,525 crore at the end of the first quarter from ₹2,77,116 crore at the end of June 2025. So in percentage terms, CASA rose to 39.73 per cent of the total deposits. The bank has taken several initiatives to augment CASA to 40 per cent of total deposits during this year, he said. The average balance in savings accounts has more than doubled to ₹53,000 while the current account has also seen an improvement in average balance to ₹1.36 lakh to ₹1.90 lakh, he said.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

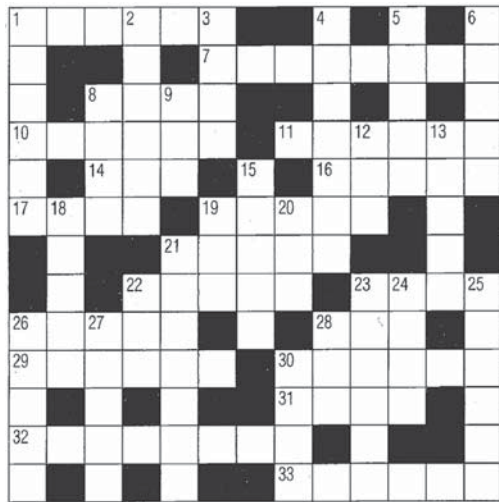
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (11.7.26)								
4	6	7	9	5	2	1	8	3
8	2	9	1	3	4	7	5	6
3	1	5	7	8	6	2	4	9
5	4	1	6	9	3	8	2	7
7	3	6	8	2	5	4	9	1
9	8	2	4	1	7	6	3	5
6	7	8	5	4	9	3	1	2
1	5	3	2	7	8	9	6	4
2	9	4	3	6	1	5	7	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | JULY 13, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 Beastly food for a chap with a broken leg
- 7 Majestic fairylike creature in Mali, possibly (8)
- 8 Be sad to see me out of work (4)
- 10 In credit, having debtors, was exultant (6)
- 11 A girl's age shows in her face (6)
- 14 In computing, abbreviation can be a trap (3)
- 16 Rings up to gas about everything (5)
- 17 Not all authors are immortal (4)
- 19 Form of address for a well balanced woman (5)
- 21 She's in the pink (5)

DOWN

- 1 Luck bringer at many a racecourse? (6)
- 2 Look unhappy when given a shiner! (6)
- 3 Used the wrong words for a song! (4)
- 4 Award given out for a bit of service as a healer (7)
- 5 Latest thing in ties (5)
- 6 Fatheaded fibs from 'pilots' (5)
- 8 Moon around, having no stereo (4)
- 9 Soft, ultimately sweet darling (3)
- 12 Uncle in a smash-up! (3)
- 13 A drink with a light-hearted girl (5)
- 15 Can they be tuned sharp? (5)
- 18 Hot-headed desire leading to delay? (5)
- 19 A shock for the cleaner (3)

- 22 Content to bring hearty chaps to extremes of penury (5)
- 23 Having to break step can be a nuisance (4)
- 26 A case of "bottoms up" at the rugby club? (5)
- 28 Master Charlie's wet weather wear (3)
- 29 Father keeps me in new hats (6)
- 30 One of relative concern in thermometer manufacture (6)
- 31 River with a bore? (4)
- 32 An understanding supporter (8)
- 33 He sounds sincere (6)

- 20 The May figure is reduced to 500, for a time (3)
- 21 Happened a great deal in a legendary town (7)
- 22 Inhuman sound? (3)
- 23 Benefactor's tap on the head for a boy (4)
- 24 A sound return (4)
- 25 Variety of trout swallowing a piece of bait? (6)
- 26 Number of employees possibly quartered (5)
- 27 Really without a key part, we gather (5)
- 28 Semi-mobile rabble (3)
- 30 Word tending to belittle me a bit more (4)

Assam CM launches state-wide drugs disposal campaign at Doulashal

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday launched the State-level Drugs Disposal Campaign at the 14th Assam Police Battalion campus at Doulashal in Nalbari district. The Chief Minister inaugurated a secure drug disposal machine installed at the battalion campus with the assistance of the Central Government. He also formally commenced the disposal process by operating a road roller over seized narcotic substances. Similar drugs disposal programmes are being carried out simultaneously across all districts of the State. Under the initiative, narcotic substances worth ₹472.51 crore seized by Assam Police, including heroin, ganja, cough syrup, tablets and capsules, opium, morphine and cocaine, will be disposed of.

Chief Minister Dr Sarma said that over the past five years, the State Government has been seizing narcotic



substances worth several hundred crore rupees every year, while courts have convicted and sentenced many persons involved in drug trafficking. He said that the Government has been periodically disposing of seized narcotic substances in public to send a strong message to drug traffickers.

The Chief Minister stated that it would take around ten days to dispose of narcotic substances worth ₹472.51 crore. He said that the Central Government had provided a specialised machine for the safe disposal of narcotic substances and that it was being used for the first time at Doulashal.

He informed that the disposal campaign would cover

58.88 kg of heroin, nearly 38,000 kg of ganja, around 2.29 lakh bottles of cough syrup, 39 kg of morphine, approximately 18.71 lakh methamphetamine and Yaba tablets, nearly 4.97 lakh tablets and capsules, besides several other narcotic substances.

Dr Sarma said that during the last five years, 3,300 cases have been registered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, while Assam Police has so far seized narcotic substances worth ₹3,227 crore. The Chief Minister said that Union Home Minister Amit Shah has been making sustained efforts to strengthen inter-State coordination in the fight against drugs, leading to significant improvement in cooperation among States in recent years.

Finance Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah, Barkhetri MLA Narayan Deka, Director General of Police Harmeet Singh and several senior officers of Assam Police were present on the occasion.

Planting saplings not enough, nurturing them important: Jayant Chaudhary



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Baghpat (UP)

Union Minister Jayant Chaudhary on Sunday called for turning environmental conservation into a mass movement, saying that merely planting saplings is not enough and their protection and nurturing are equally important.

Chaudhary planted a sapling during an event organised under the 'Ek Pedh Maa Ke Naam' campaign at Baba Shahmal Stadium in Baraut and urged people to plant more trees and pledge to look after them.

The Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 'LiFE' (Lifestyle for Environment) initiative has gained global recognition, with the United Nations also praising the initiative and passing a resolution regarding environmental conservation. Chaudhary said that when people's emotions become connected to a campaign, it naturally evolves into a mass movement. He described the 'Ek Pedh Maa Ke Naam' campaign as a powerful medium for uniting nature, family and society. He urged citizens to plant as many saplings as possible and to take responsibility for their protection.

CAIT welcomes Govt's decision to launch High-Frequency Economic Barometer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) has welcomed the Government of India's decision to launch the High-Frequency Economic Barometer on July 14, describing it as a historic and transformative initiative under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to make economic governance more modern, dynamic, and data-



ership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to make economic governance more modern, dynamic, and data-

driven. Praveen Khandelwal, Member of Parliament from Chandni Chowk, Delhi, and Secretary General of CAIT, said that Prime Minister Modi has elevated economic transparency and efficiency to new heights through initiatives such as Digital India, GST, UPI, and technology-driven governance.

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Gold, silver under pressure amid US-Iran tensions

Gold and silver are expected to remain volatile with a corrective bias in the coming week as investors assess the latest flare-up in the US-Iran conflict, movements in crude oil prices and inflation data that could reshape expectations for global interest rates, analysts said.

Fresh hostilities in West Asia have once again put markets on edge. The latest round of tensions began after Iran said it had struck a vessel travelling on an unapproved route and subsequently announced the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. The US Central Command later said it carried out strikes on Tehran, following which Iran retaliated by targeting American-linked installations in the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, and Bahrain. Analysts said any further escalation in the conflict could drive crude oil prices higher, revive inflation concerns and strengthen safe-haven assets such as the US dollar and Treasury yields, limiting the upside for precious metals.

Besides geopolitical developments, markets will closely watch inflation data from India, the EU, and the United States for fresh clues on the monetary policy trajectory of major global central banks, he said. (PTI)

Two-wheelers biggest hurdle for Delhi EV policy

The two-wheeler category presents a bigger challenge for the recently announced Delhi EV policy, which will ban the registration of conventional-engine bikes and scooters from April 2028, with electric penetration in the segment at just 7.3 per cent in Delhi in FY26, according to Crisil Ratings.

While the 'April 2028 EV-only registration' requirement provides a clear roadmap for the two-wheeler industry to accelerate investments in electric products, capacity and distribution, internal combustion engine (ICE) models are expected to remain relevant in the near term, Crisil Ratings Director Poonam Upadhyay told PTI.

The future growth in Delhi's two-wheeler market will increasingly be linked to EV readiness, she said, responding to a query about the policy's implications for ICE manufacturers, especially in the two-wheeler category. (PTI)

Weak monsoon may lift soluble fertiliser demand; price remains bigger risk: SFAI

LAXMI DEVI AERE ■ New Delhi

An uncertain monsoon could work in favour of India's soluble fertiliser makers this Kharif season, but a sharp rise in prices poses a bigger risk to demand, industry body SFAI said on Sunday.

Prices of key inputs have surged 60-100 per cent over the past year due to China's export curbs and disruptions linked to tensions in West Asia, Soluble Fertilizer Association of India (SFAI) President Rajib Chakraborty said. "Current prices are almost 60 to 100 per cent up," Chakraborty told PTI, adding that monoammonium phosphate (MAP), which sold for around \$1,000 per tonne over

the last couple of years, is now trading at \$1,500-1,600 per tonne.

"An increase of \$600 per tonne means it's a big thing," he noted. Asked about the biggest risk to the sector this season, Chakraborty said it was the possibility of a drop in consumption due to the price rise.

"The moment it becomes very expensive, farmers stop using it," he said, adding that price control was not possible or within the industry's control.

China's restrictions on exports of key products, coupled with the West Asia crisis, have disrupted shipments to India, forcing importers to explore alterna-

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JULY 13, 2026

Mass tree planting key to green future: Chouhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Sunday called for a mass tree planting movement for a greener future.

Addressing the 'Paryavaran Sanrakshan Sankalp' and 'Vriksh Mitra Dialogue' here at the PUSA campus, Chouhan said every family celebrate occasions such as birthdays, wedding anniversaries, the birth of children and the remembrance of departed parents by planting trees, thereby turning every personal milestone into a 'Tree Festival'.

He urged every Vriksh Mitra to plant at least one tree annually and inspire at least five more people to join the campaign, with participants publicly sharing their commitment on social media to build a strong nationwide network by "Hariyali Amavasya" on August 12.

The minister also unveiled a comprehensive roadmap to transform environmental protection into a structured mass campaign,

drawing upon suggestions from Vriksh Mitras during the interaction.

The minister further proposed the formation of 'Vriksh Mitra Parivar' committees at the national, state, district, block and village levels to provide an organ-

every auspicious occasion and government programme, including the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Lakhpati Didi Yojana, and initiatives of the Agriculture and Rural Development Ministry, should begin with tree plantation.

Around 17,000 Vriksh Mitra from across the country participated in the programme. Padma Bhushan environmentalist Anil Joshi, renowned physician and social worker Anup Hajela, Director General of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research, and ML Jat were present at the event.

Together, they resolved to promote tree plantation, water conservation, soil protection, energy efficiency and a plastic-free lifestyle through public participation to safeguard the planet, the statement said.

The minister said that tree plantation efforts would no longer remain scattered initiatives but would be brought under an organised nationwide network named 'Vriksh Mitra Parivar'.

Banks' treasury gains to improve in Q1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Banks are likely to report mark-to-market (MTM) gains on investment portfolios in the April-June period of the current fiscal year as Government bond yields softened sharply after surging in the preceding quarter, analysts said.

However, these gains' influence on profitability is expected to be limited because of the accounting treatment of investments, according to the analysts.

"The yields softened in Q1 FY2027 after having risen sharply towards the end of Q4 FY2026. Consequently, banks are expected to witness mark-to-market (MTM) gains on their investment portfolios. However, the impact of same on profitability may be only partial, as fair value changes

on investments classified under the Available for Sale (AFS) category are recognised directly in net worth," said Sachin Sachdeva, Vice President, Sector Head, Financial Sector Ratings at ICRA.

The benchmark 10-year Government bond yield witnessed a sharp reversal over the two quarters. During the January-March 2026 quarter, the yield rose 0.45 per cent from 6.582 per cent at the start of January to 7.035 per cent at the end of March, with a sharp sell-off in the last week of March pushing the benchmark above the 7 per cent mark.

This was mainly because of rising oil prices amid the West Asia crisis, which directly feeds into domestic retail inflation and widens the trade and current account deficit.

Piyush Goyal to visit Spain, Belgium, Finland this week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will embark on a five-day visit to Spain, Belgium, and Finland to discuss ways to boost trade and investments between India and the three countries, an official statement said on Sunday.

The delegation comprises leading Indian companies across sectors, including advanced manufacturing, clean energy, digital technologies, gems and jewellery, food processing, healthcare, and design, the Commerce Ministry said.

In Spain on July 13, the minister will participate in a business roundtable, which will bring together Spanish and Indian industry leaders to explore opportunities in automotive, renewable energy, railways, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, food processing, and tourism.

Spanish companies such as Iberdrola, Acciona, CAF, Talgo, Gestamp, and Indra already have strong footprints in India, while Indian firms, including TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Tech Mahindra, and

L&T, are expanding operations in Spain. In Belgium on July 14-15, Goyal will hold CEO-level meetings with Alain Quervin of Thales Group and Jean-Christophe Bogaert of Silox Group.

Thales is a global leader in aerospace, defence, cybersecurity, and digital identity, with partnerships in India, while Silox is a speciality chemicals and recycling group with major operations in Gujarat and collaborations in battery recycling and sustainable manufacturing.

"The India-EU Business Roundtable and TTC (trade and technology council) plenary will further focus on foreign direct investment opportunities, trade facilitation, sustainable technologies, and resilient supply chains," the ministry said.

Sri Lanka new hotspot for Indian weddings in 2025

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Sri Lanka has emerged as the fastest-growing destination for Indian weddings abroad in 2025, with a 25 per cent rise in popularity, and despite challenges posed by the ongoing West Asia crisis, couples are unlikely to cut down plans for their big occasion this year, according to a report.

Accessibility, proximity to India, luxury hospitality infrastructure, and experience-led celebrations have propelled Sri Lanka as a fast-emerging destination wedding centre, WedMeGood, a leading wedding planning platform, said in its Destination Wedding Report 2026.

India and Canada concluded the third round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in Ottawa on July 10, as the two sides look to wind up the talks this year itself.

The issues that figured in the five-day talks include trade in goods, services, intellectual property, rules of origin, sanitary and phytosanitary measures, and technical barriers to trade, among others.

Indian wedding bookings to Sri Lanka are projected to grow 20-25 per cent annually over the next few years, as per the report.

Shangri-La (Hambantota), Shangri-La (Colombo), Amaya Hills (Kandy), The

Grand Hotel (Nuwara Eliya), and Jetwing Lagoon (Negombo) were the top-booked properties in Sri Lanka in 2025, as per the report.

Thailand, though, remained the most popular destination with close to 25 lakh arrivals in 2025, registering a 16 per cent increase year-on-year.

In 2025, one in every four weddings surveyed were destination events, and the number is expected to go up to 30-32 per cent by 2028, it said.

The report was based on findings from a survey distributed across both WedMeGood's consumer and industry networks. About 2.5 lakh B2C users and around 24,000 wedding industry professionals/vendors were surveyed.

India, Canada conclude third round of trade talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and Canada concluded the third round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in Ottawa on July 10, as the two sides look to wind up the talks this year itself.

The issues that figured in the five-day talks include trade in goods, services, intellectual property, rules of origin, sanitary and phytosanitary measures, and technical barriers to trade, among others.

"India and Canada concluded the 3rd Round of negotiations for the India-Canada CEPA in Ottawa from 6-10 July 2026. The discussions witnessed positive progress across multiple negotiating tracks, reaffirming the shared commitment of both countries to con-

clude the negotiations in 2026, in line with the vision of the leaders," the Department of Commerce said in a social media post.

The negotiations are important as the two sides have targeted to increase the bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030.

In 2025-26, the two-way trade dipped 8.22 per cent to \$7.95 billion (\$4.67 billion exports and \$3.28 billion imports) from \$8.66 billion in 2024-25 (\$4.22 billion exports and \$4.44 billion imports).

tives such as Russia and the CIS region, he said, adding that availability from these sources also remains limited.

Domestic manufacturing of soluble fertiliser is minimal, he said, leaving little scope to bridge the import shortfall

from within the country. Despite the price rise, the immediate supply situation was not alarming due to a

NTPC clears ₹20,457 cr Lara stage-III project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

State-run power giant NTPC board has approved ₹20,456.70-crore investment for 1,600 MW Lara Super Thermal Power Project Stage-III in Chhattisgarh.

"The Board of Directors of NTPC Limited in its meeting held today, ie 11th July 2026 has, inter-alia, approved investment proposal for Lara Super Thermal Power Project, Stage-III (2x800 MW) at current estimated cost of ₹20,456.70 crore," the company said in an exchange filing on Saturday.

On June 5, the NTPC had sought bids from technolo-

gy solutions players to help its sub-critical thermal power units operate at lower load and ensure flexibility for the electricity distribution

network to use both thermal and renewable energy more efficiently.

The project will require providing technical support

to sub-critical thermal units ranging between 150 MW and 250 MW, enabling them to operate in two shifts and at a minimum technical load of 25 per cent, NTPC had said in a statement.

Sub-critical thermal units can offer greater flexibility compared to supercritical and ultra-supercritical technologies for certain grid-balancing requirements because of less parameter swings and hence low fatigue, NTPC had said, adding that their ability to operate efficiently at lower loads and adapt to frequent cycling makes them a potential enabler for higher renewable energy integration in the future.

Geopolitical situation, earnings, crude prices key factors to drive markets, say analysts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The US-Iran geopolitical conflict, quarterly earnings announcements, and crude oil price movement will influence investor sentiments in domestic equities, according to analysts.

Besides, monsoon trend, inflation data and trading activity of foreign investors will also be closely watched by market participants, they added.

"Domestically, investors will closely monitor June CPI inflation, WPI inflation, and the latest foreign exchange reserves," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

The Q1 FY27 earnings season will gather pace, with management commentary expected to play a pivotal role

in shaping sectoral trends and earnings expectations, he said.

Globally, developments surrounding the Iran-US conflict and their impact on crude oil prices will remain key monitorables, Mishra added.

After four straight months of selling, foreign investors turned net buyers of Indian equities in July, investing over

₹15,157 crore so far this month, supported by improving domestic macroeconomic indicators, a stable rupee and better global risk sentiment.

"This week will see earnings from several companies, including HCL Technologies, Tech Mahindra, Union Bank, Federal Bank," Santosh Meena, Head of Research at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said. On the macroeconomic front, inflation data will remain an important trigger, he said.

India's Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation will be released on Monday, followed by the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) on Tuesday, Meena said, adding that investors will also closely monitor the progress of monsoon, given its implications for rural demand and inflation.

BRIEFLY

Jeev Milkha Singh tied-20th in Irish Legends



Jeev Milkha Singh carded a two-under 70 in the second round to lie Tied-20th with one more round to go in the 54-hole OFX Irish Legends at Carton House. The Indian ace, who is seeking his first Seniors title, is dividing his time between multiple Tours around the world, including Indian Golf Premier League and Senior Tours in Europe and Japan. Robert Coles produced a stunning late birdie blitz to open up a three-shot lead heading into the final round after a second consecutive seven-under-par 65. Coles leads the way on 14-under-par, with Sweden's Johan Edfors his closest challenger on 11-under after climbing five places with a brilliant six-under-par 66. Overnight leader Emanuele Canonica slipped back to third on nine-under, while 2014 Ryder Cup player Stephen Gallacher and 1999 Open Champion Paul Lawrie shared fifth on seven-under. Just one shot further back, big-hitting Englishman Craig Farrelly remains firmly in contention on six-under as he looks to secure a maiden Staysure Legends Tour title. With just 18 holes remaining, Coles will look to secure his second Staysure Legends Tour title, while Edfors and Farrelly are both chasing breakthrough victories on the over-50 circuit. (PTI)

Scottish Open: Indian-origin players slip on day 3



Indian-origin golfers Sudarshan Yellamaraju and Sahith Theegala slipped on the Scottish Open leaderboard but still had holes left to complete in the third round when play was suspended due to a delayed start here. Indo-Canadian Yellamaraju, who was in the top 10 through the first half of the tournament, was even par after 13 holes on Saturday, with two birdies and two bogeys, but dropped from tied sixth to tied 17th. Theegala struggled on a day affected by foggy weather, carding five bogeys against a late birdie on the 14th. He had one more hole to complete but slipped from tied 38th to tied 64th. Matt Fitzpatrick, who is enjoying a brilliant season, and Michael Thorbjornsen shared the lead after a weather-interrupted third day at the tournament, which is being played just before the final Major of the season. Thorbjornsen birdied his last two holes to reach 11-under through 13 holes, while Fitzpatrick missed the green on the eighth and failed to save par before play was halted. He was also at 11-under with more holes still to complete on Sunday. (PTI)

Dhiraj, Kirti Sharma squander 3-1 lead, misses Archery World Cup bronze

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Madrid

India's recurve mixed pair of Dhiraj Bommadevara and Kirti Sharma squandered a promising 3-1 lead to miss out on the bronze medal, losing 3-5 to Italy at the Archery World Cup Stage 4, here on Sunday.

For Dhiraj, the Antalya World Cup champion, it was a disappointing end to the campaign as he returned empty-handed from Madrid despite having won the recurve mixed team gold with Kumkum Mohod at the third stage last month.

With the defeat, India's



hopes in the recurve section now rest solely on Kirti, who will compete in the individual semifinals later on Sunday. A victory there would clinch the 19-year-old her maiden World Cup medal. Kirti made her World

Norway's WC run ends, England reach semifinals

TIM REYNOLDS
■ Miami Gardens (US)

Erling Haaland's day ended earlier than many expected. About 15 minutes later, Norway's run in the World Cup ended as well.

The Vikings' biggest star didn't shine Saturday.

Haaland was a nonfactor for much of his team's quarterfinal against England and — at least in part because of the strain of dealing with hot and humid conditions in South Florida — was taken out with Norway's hopes hanging in the balance going into the final 15 minutes of extra time.

The final score: England 2, Norway 1. Haaland was kept

off the scoresheet for the first time in this World Cup; he had scored seven times in his four appearances going into Saturday, but barely had a chance to add to that total Saturday.

"This has been an insane journey," Haaland said.

Haaland acknowledged afterward that his energy was gone as the game, which was played with a heat index topping 100 degrees Fahrenheit (38 Celsius), wore along. "It was not a tough decision to take him out," Norway coach Stale Solbakken said. "He was finished. Maybe I should have taken him out 10 minutes before. ... He also got a dead leg in the second half, so that



combined with the fatigue. He did everything he could."

The Manchester City striker was, without question, one of the stars of the tournament — but England silenced him. And his former Borussia

Dortmund teammate, Jude Bellingham, wound up stealing the show by scoring both goals. Haaland and Bellingham shared an embrace when the game ended, before the Norwegian

Messi's World Cup scoring streak ends, but his assist sparks Argentina's win over Switzerland

DAVE SKRETTA
■ Kansas City (US)

Lionel Messi had his World Cup scoring streak snapped by Switzerland on Saturday night, but the co-leader with France's Kylian Mbappe in the race for the Golden Boot nevertheless found his way to leave his mark with an assist in Argentina's 3-1 victory.

The game was only in the 10th minute when Messi — who needed some help from a trainer after a blow near his right eye in the second half — helped to earn a corner kick with some nifty footwork. From there, the Inter Miami star delivered a perfect ball into the box,



and Alexis Mac Allister was there to head it home for a 1-0 lead.

Switzerland equalised in the 67th minute and the game eventually went to

defending champions.

Now, Argentina will play England in the semifinals on Wednesday in Atlanta.

One of the first questions asked of Swiss coach Murat Yakin before the match was how to stop Messi, who had scored in his last nine World Cup matches, his last six in the knockout round. He also holds the tournament record with 21 career goals.

"This is a very surprising question," Yakin replied, jokingly. "There are many solutions, and we will try to find the best solution. ... We can talk a lot about it, but in the end it has to really translate onto the pitch, and we do have our solutions." (AP)

Aditi moves to tied-33rd at Evian Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Evian-Les-Bains (France)

Indian golfer Aditi Ashok carded a 2-under 69 to make a marginal improvement over her first two rounds and move into a tie for 33rd place with one round remaining at the \$9.1 million Evian Championship here.

Aditi, who shot identical 70s in the opening two rounds on the par-71 course, is competing in her 38th Major.

The talking point of the day was South Korea's Haeran Ryu, who produced a stunning performance in the third round, firing a course-record 60 (11-under) to storm into a three-shot lead at the 54-hole stage. Aditi, who has featured



in the most Majors by any Indian golfer — male or female — with 38 appearances, made four birdies against two bogeys, with her gains and set-backs evenly split across the front and back nine.

She picked up birdies on the second and seventh holes while dropping a shot on the fourth. On the back nine, she birdied the 12th and 16th holes, with a bogey on the 14th.

South Africa WC midfielder Jayden Adams dies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Johannesburg

South Africa midfielder Jayden Adams, who played at the World Cup, has died. He was 25. His death was confirmed by Gayton McKenzie, South Africa's minister of sport, arts and culture, in a statement on Saturday.

"It is with profound shock and a heavy heart that I have learnt of the passing of Jayden Adams, midfielder for Mamelodi Sundowns and Bafana Bafana, at the age of 25," McKenzie posted on X.

"South African football has lost one of its brightest young talents, and our nation mourns alongside his family, his team-mates and the millions of supporters." Adams helped South Africa



reach the World Cup knockout stage for the first time. Further details of his death were not given.

"The cause of Jayden's passing has not yet been confirmed," McKenzie said. "I wish to appeal to members of the media and the public to exercise restraint and compassion, and to refrain from speculation."

A moment of silence in honour of Adams was held

ahead of the World Cup quarterfinal between Norway and England in Miami Gardens, Florida, on Saturday.

Adams started in South Africa's first Group A games against Mexico and the Czech Republic. McKenzie said Adams played the second game only hours after learning that his grandmother had died. He came on as a second-half substi-

tute in the third game against South Korea. Adams played several seasons for Stellenbosch before joining Mamelodi Sundowns last year. He helped the club win the CAF (African) Champions League this year.

"Death has cruelly stolen one of our own. It has robbed our nation of a remarkable footballer," the South African Football Players Union posted on X.

"We will forever remember his humility, his extraordinary talent and the pride with which he represented South Africa. Rest in eternal peace, Jayden. You will never be forgotten."

South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and the South African Federation of Trade Unions also expressed their condolences.



card, leaving the Swiss to play the remainder of a game tied 1-1 with only 10 players.

It was a massive momentum swing after Switzerland's Dan Ndoye had tied the game moments earlier.

It's the second time a yellow card has been overturned using the "mistaken identity" protocol at the World Cup.

Prince, Bishnoi in squad for England ODIs, Zimbabwe T20Is

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

Young pacer Harshit Rana and veteran spinner Varun Chakravarthi have been ruled out of competitive cricket for indefinite period due to hamstring injuries of various degrees, while Prince Yadav and Ravi Bishnoi named as their replacements for India's upcoming ODI and T20I assignments respectively. Prince will be linking up with the ODI squad in England in the absence of Rana.

Leg-spinner Bishnoi, whose expensive 17th over that went for 29 runs, the single biggest reason for India's defeat in the second T20I against England at Old Trafford, got a lifeline after replacing



Chakravarthi for the three-match T20I series in Zimbabwe starting later this month. "Rana reported a sudden onset of discomfort in his right hamstring during the third T20I against England at Trent Bridge. Subsequent scans revealed a Grade 1

hamstring injury," BCCI said in a statement.

"He has been ruled out of the forthcoming ODI series against England and will report to the BCCI Centre of Excellence (COE) for further assessment and management," it further stated.

In case of Chakravarthi, it is a grade 2 injury which could well keep him out for three to six months depending on the speed of his rehabilitation. He is soon to be 35 and it will be interesting as to how much time his ageing body takes to recover.

"Chakaravarthi also reported a sudden onset of discomfort in his left hamstring during the third T20I against England. An MRI scan subsequently revealed a Grade 2 hamstring injury. "Based on specialist medical advice, he has been ruled out of the upcoming T20I series against Zimbabwe. He will report to the BCCI COE for further management," BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia was quoted as saying.

West Indies beats New Zealand by 7 wickets in the 1st ODI

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Providence (Guyana)

Keacy Carty was dismissed on 95 and Shai Hope made an unbeaten 87 in a 131-run third wicket partnership which steered the West Indies to a seven wicket win over New Zealand on Saturday in the first of five one-day cricket internationals.

Carty fell just short of his fifth ODI century, a year after his fourth, as the West Indies



surpassed New Zealand's total of 267 with seven balls remaining. Hope anchored the innings after his partner's dismissal, adding 45 runs from 31 balls in an unbroken partnership with Sherfane Rutherford who finished 22 not out.

Pakistan fielding coach Shane McDermott resigns ahead of tour to West Indies, England

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Pakistan fielding coach Shane McDermott has resigned ahead of their upcoming tour to the West Indies and England after a year-long stint.

A reliable source close to the Pakistan Cricket Board said McDermott will not travel with the team on those aforementioned tours.



The PCB is keen to appoint Mansoor Amjad, who has worked with Shaheens and Under-19 teams, as the Australian's replacement. "Mansoor Amjad who has been the fielding coach with the Pakistan Shaheens and under-19 is likely to replace McDermott," the source said. Pakistan will leave on Monday for the two-Test tour to the Caribbean, and subsequently will travel to

England for three Tests.

The PCB has not specified any reason for McDermott's resignation, and it has added another instance to a foreign coach leaving his assignment in Pakistan cricket in unexplained circumstances.

Recent examples being the outgoing trainer/physio Cliffe Deacon, and the resignations of head coaches, Gary Kirsten and Jason Gillespie.

Failure to adapt cost us: Iyer after losing T20I series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Southampton

India failed to adapt to English conditions and were outplayed by England and Ireland, skipper Shreyas Iyer said, adding that experience would only make him a better leader.

Iyer endured a disastrous start to his captaincy after taking over from Suryakumar Yadav, as the team suffered a 0-2 defeat to Ireland before



losing the T20I series 0-4 to England. "It's not hard, honestly," said Iyer during post-match press conference.